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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

BASANTA SHRAWAN CEREMONY OBSERVED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

A Basanta Shrawan programme was held at Nasalchowk in Hanumandhoka Durbar Square on the occasion of Basanta Panchami or Shree Panchami. President Ramchandra Paudel attended the ceremony in the morning.

It is customary for the President to visit Nasalchowk on the occasion of Saraswati Puja for Basanta Shrawan (listening to mantras).

President Paudel, Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Chief Justice, Deputy Prime Minister and others attended the Basanta Shrawan ceremony.

On the occasion, President Paudel received garlands, tika and prasad from the priests and offered prayers to Goddess Saraswati. The Vice President, Prime Minister and others also received tika and prasad on the occasion.

The Basanta Shrawan programme in which 12 verses were recited by priests was held at the auspicious hour of 11: 05 am.

Shree Panchami is celebrated on the fifth day of the waxing moon in the month of Magh according to the Nepali calendar. It is believed that from this day, the sun starts moving to the northern hemisphere, causing longer days and signalling the beginning of the spring season.

Marriage ceremonies and other religious functions are also performed on this day as the day is believed to be auspicious.

Different schools and educational institutions organised Saraswati Puja today. Traditionally, children are taught to write their first letter on the day of Saraswati Puja.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

(From right) President Ramchandra Paudel, Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' gracing the Basanta Shrawan ceremony on the occasion of Basanta Panchami at Nasalchowk of Hanumandhoka in Kathmandu on Wednesday.

President stresses soil-friendly farming, tech-friendly education

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Phidim, Feb. 14

President Ramchandra Paudel has stressed the need for soil-friendly farming and technology-friendly education in the country.

"Stopping youth migration, modernising traditional agricultural system and adopting technology in education are the need of the day. If agriculture could be modernised, the fertile fields of the mountains will remain green and full forever," President Paudel said while inaugurating the Shrimadbhagwat Gyan Mahayagya and multi-religious spiritual festival in Phidim of Panchthar district on Wednesday.

He also said that education policy and curriculum should be competitive and technologically advanced to enhance the quality of education and check the youth migration.

"The country will develop only through the agricultural revolution, the expansion of tourism and the abundant development of energy power. For that the first need is good governance and we need to develop a culture that respects labour, our education should be focused on these issues," President Paudel said.

"We have failed to recognise the fertile soil and clean climate in the homeland and have also been misled by meaningless slogans. Let's plan to grow food according to the altitude, and harness the natural blessings," he added.

The President stressed that the next steps should be focused on providing education in accordance with national needs and international quality by developing education policy, curriculum and technologically competitive and quality teaching as per the demands of the current world environment, which is overwhelmed by information technology, globalisation and modernity.

The Mahayagya is being organised by Panchthar Multiple Campus and will run for the next eight days. The donations raised by the Yagya will be used to add facilities to the campus and improve the quality of education.

Dr. Chandra Kumar Sherma will deliver a speech on Kirant Mundhum and Furtemba Sherpa on Buddhist philosophy. The event is organised under the leadership of Pandit Dinbandhu Pokharel, said Deepak Prakash Baskota, Chairman of the Board of Directors of Panchthar Multiple Campus.

Police seize server of four cooperatives linked to GB Rai

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

In a shocking turn of events, the police have uncovered transaction details of over Rs. 10 billion related to Gitendra Babu Rai, popularly known as GB Rai, who is currently on the run after allegedly embezzling deposits of over 19,000 persons from the Pokhara-based Surya Darshan Saving and Credit Cooperatives.

The revelations include details from four cooperatives, including Surya Darshan Cooperatives operated by GB, discovered on servers seized from the residence of a former Deputy Inspector General (DIG) of Nepal Police.

On Wednesday last week, authorities conducted a raid on the home of former DIG Chhabilal Joshi at Shankhamul in Kathmandu, seizing four servers of the cooperatives. According to the police, former DIG Joshi had a 35 per cent stake in Galaxy Television, GB Rai 50 per cent and Rastriya Swatantray Party (RSP) President Rabi Lamichhane 1 per cent as sweat equity. The house of Joshi was used as the office of Nature Herbs Pvt. Ltd, operated by Rai.

Former DIG Joshi, identified as one of the business partners of GB Rai, had reportedly concealed the servers containing crucial cooperative information, according to the police.

The District Police Range Kathmandu, acting on information from the Kaski District Police Office, raided Joshi's residence, seized the servers and took them to the Kaski Police Office for further investigation.

> The investigation officer revealed that the servers contained transaction details of Pokhara's Surya Darshan Cooperative, Chitwan's Sahara Cooperative, Birgunj's Sanopaila Cooperative and Butwal's Supreme Cooperative.

The Kaski Police, currently probing allegations of swindling depositors over millions of rupees from Surya Darshan Cooperative, has also discovered transaction details of other cooperatives affiliated with GB Rai.

The investigation officer revealed that the servers contained transaction details of Pokhara's Surya Darshan Cooperative, Chitwan's Sahara Cooperative, Birgunj's Sanopaila Cooperative and Butwal's Supreme Cooperative.

The transaction details of these cooperatives, exceeding Rs. 10 billion, have prompted a comprehensive investigation, said one of the investigation officers of the Pokhara District Police Office. "We have recovered the transaction details of four cooperatives including Surya Darshan and this will be going to be strong evidence to further probe the investigation," said an investigation officer while talking to The Rising Nepal on Wednesday.

GB Rai, the cooperative owner, allegedly hid the servers at the former DIG's residence to avoid accountability and keep the record safe, said police.

Upon receiving a complaint and initiating an investigation, authorities discovered the servers' location at the former DIG's house, prompting the raid.

"Rai might have hidden the servers at Joshi's house because they would not be able to keep track of the amount to be collected when the servers were destroyed," said the officer.

"They thought it would be safe to keep it in the house of a former police officer."

But after we got the information, we raided and seized them," said an officer on a condition of anonymity.

GB Rai is currently evading law enforcement with reports suggesting he might be in Malaysia.

Interpol's assistance has been sought to apprehend and bring him back to Nepal. A diffusion notice against Rai has also been issued for his arrest and deportation to Kathmandu, said police.

Of the individuals arrested so far, five have been remanded in custody while 14 remain at large.

The District Court Kaski has ordered Surya Darshan Cooperative's former directors Shiva Bahadur Gurung and Bhabishwar Aryal, treasurer Kumar Ramtel, former Vice-president Kailash Darlami Magar and board member Pramod Bhattarai to be sent to prison until the final hearing.

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MINISTER SAUD HOLDS TALKS WITH NEW ZEALAND DPM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud, on Wednesday held bilateral meeting with Winston Peters, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade (MFAT) of New Zealand in Wellington.

During the meeting, both sides exchanged views on enhancing cooperation in the areas of mutual interests, Embassy of Nepal in Canberra of Australia (which is also accredited to New Zealand) informed in a statement on Wednesday.

In the afternoon, FM Saud visited the Parliament of New Zealand and observed the 'Question Time' in the Parliament.

His presence in the Parliament was acknowledged by Gerry Brownlee, the Speaker of the House of Representatives of New Zealand.

The Nepali Society in Wellington together with the Honorary Consul of Nepal to New Zealand organised an interaction programme with the Minister and the visiting delegation.

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CPN-MC statute convention

Group leaders suggest changing party's name, election symbol

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

The first Statute Convention of the CPN (Maoist Centre) continued for the second day in Kathmandu on Wednesday.

On the second day, 13 of the 20 groups presented their suggestions. The group leaders suggested that the party should be organised and made active by running it according to the concept of federalism.

Presenting suggestions from his group, Kanchan Khanal proposed that the party's General Convention representatives should be elected from party committee members and the family members of martyrs and disappeared and injured party workers members should be made observers in the general convention of the party. Additionally, the party should become transparent and friendly, encompassing all regions and communities.

Saral Sahayatri suggested that proposals should be simplified and the organisational principles should be shortened. He said that the party and its election symbol should be changed and the distribution of party membership should be simplified. He said that additional emphasis should be given to election, finance and discipline and the date of the General Convention should be mentioned.

Yuvaraj Chaulagain suggested that the party committee should be formed through direct elections. Stating that there was no need to mention the party's standing committee members in the statute, he said that the candidates for all levels of public positions within and outside the party should be decided by party members.

Himal Sharma suggested a provision for direct election for officials. Meanwhile, a turn system should be arranged for appointments in different positions of state affairs. He also said that the provinces should be given additional authority.

Dilip Kumar Prajapati expressed confidence that the new statute would bring party to the public. He suggested that caste-based discrimination should be treated as a serious crime and the number of central members should be reduced.

Similarly, Kumar Paudel suggested that the statute should be passed and implemented for the structural operation of the party.

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Baitadi's 2-km ring road fails to complete in 26 years

BY GOKARNA DAYAL
Baitadi, Feb. 14

Construction of a two-kilometre urban ring road in Dasharathchanda Municipality-4, which becomes a political agenda in every election, has remained incomplete even 26 years after works on it began.

Despite promises from all leaders during the election campaign to construct the urban ring road, it has been left neglected once the elections are over.

The ring road project connecting Shahilek to Devalhat and Badilekh to Gothalapani in Ward No.-4, which began in 1997, has come to a halt due to budgetary constraints. The primary aim for building this road was to link Panchadeval of the Pandav era in Ward No. 4 of the municipality with Tripurasundari, a religious tourist destination.

Local youth Naresh Thagunna expressed his frustration, stating that the road, which was a key electoral promise, has not been constructed to facilitate year-round vehicular movement. Locals are dismayed, alleging that the road has remained untouched since the victory in the election, no elected representative has allocated the budget for its construction.

One local, Sher Singh Bhandari stated that they were frustrated over the slow pace of development, citing the unfinished two-kilometre road project spanning 26 years. Bhandari highlighted the lack of essential infrastructure such as walls, drains, and pavements along the road, making even walking a challenge.

Locals lament that despite intermittent small-scale initiatives, the elected representatives have shown little interest in completing the road construction within a year by paving the road.

Regarding the road, the Ward Chairman of Dasharathchanda Municipality-4, Bhandev Bhatta said that although the number one priority of the ring road is included in the plan, there is no budget.

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NEA opens PPA for hydel projects up to 10 MW

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has decided to open Power Purchase Agreement (PPA) for hydropower projects up to 10 megawatts to encourage domestic small investment in hydropower.

The 963rd meeting of the NEA's Board of Directors chaired by Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet recently decided to sign PPA with the run-of-the-river (RoR) and semi-reservoir (PRoR) hydropower projects of up to 10 megawatts.

The power generated by the small projects will be purchased on the basis of 'take or pay' provision, according to the NEA.

The electricity of such projects will be purchased at Rs. 8.40 per unit for the dry season (December to May) and Rs. 4.80 per unit for the rainy season (June- November).

Managing Director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that the PPA limit (quota) set at the generation mix in the projects up to 10 megawatts would not be applied in order to encourage the maximum use of local natural resources and the investment of domestic small investors in hydropower sector.



"Due to the quota, PPAs for hydropower projects up to 10 megawatts were not possible. Now, the quota is no longer applicable to the projects up to 10 megawatts, PPAs can be made whatever the capacity is, this will encourage small domestic investors," said Ghising.

"Now we will make the PPA of hydropower projects up to 10 megawatts that have and will be under Grid Connection Agreement."

Eighty-nine projects up to 10 MW have applied to the Authority for PPA. The capacity of these projects is 351 MW, said the NEA. Of them, 44 projects of 195 megawatts have already completed grid connection agreement.

Based on the goal of producing 15,000 megawatts power in the next 10 years, the production mix was decided so that 25 per cent of reservoir projects, 30 per cent of peaking RoR, and 45 per cent of RoR would be part of the power system.

The limit of PPA was fixed on the same basis. Since the limit of 6,750 megawatts set for RoR projects has been completed, projects up to 10 megawatts have not had PPA.

Most of the projects up to 10 MW are RoR. The Authority has completed the PPA for 9,200 MW so far.

NEA to purchase added electricity

The Board of Directors of the Authority has decided to purchase additional electricity if the capacity of the hydropower projects that have made PPA has increased.

The Authority has decided that the limit of PPA will not be applied if the installed capacity of the project increases up to 25 per cent.

Ghising said that the PPA would be amended with a provision to 'take or pay' the electricity produced by increasing the installed capacity up to 25 per cent after making changes in the design of the project.

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BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 116,500
Worked Gold	: Rs. 115,950
Silver	: Rs. 1,365

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,076.50
Total Amount	: 4,252,722,895.26
No. of Share	: 12,363,027

Karnali collects 55% revenue of annual target in seven months

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Feb. 14



The Karnali provincial government has collected 55 per cent of revenue of its annual target in the first seven months of the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 when the federal government is struggling to meet its target and could only collect about 40 per cent revenue against its target during the same period.

Provincial stakeholders in Karnali said that this was a satisfactory achievement of the government.

The federal government had estimated revenue of Rs. 1, 422 billion for this year. According to the Financial Comptroller General Office (FCGO)'s report, the federal government could collect only Rs. 515 billion in the first six months of this year – it is about 23 per cent less than the half-yearly target of Rs. 668 billion. By the end of the seven months, revenue mobilisation of the federal government stands at Rs. 570 billion.

The Karnali government estimated revenue of Rs. 836.2 million this year. By mid-February, it has collected Rs. 462 million. In the last fiscal year 2022/23, the provincial government collected revenue of Rs. 636 million. Out of that, Rs. 352.5 were collected in the first seven months.

Bidya Prasad Upadhyaya, officer of the Budget and Programme Division at the Ministry of Economic Affairs and Planning, said that there has been an improvement in revenue collection this year compared to the previous years.

According to him, the ministry has increased its activity in revenue collection with a dedicated plan. The team assigned by the Ministry has reached the local levels of different districts and instructed them to deposit the revenue in the Provincial Treasury on a monthly basis.

Although the revenue collection has improved as per the target, the budget expenditure is not satisfactory. The Karnali government had allocated Rs. 33.37 billion for the current FY but only 15 per cent of the total budget has been spent in the seven months.

According to the Ministry, the government in Karnali receives revenue under 32 different headings. Out of that, it received a grant of Rs. 105 million received from the federal government. Apart from that, it has collected Rs. 85.9 million from vehicle tax, Rs. 40.6 million from real estate registration fees, Rs. 32.8 from forest area royalty, and Rs. 25.3 million from other sources.

Similarly, driver's license and vehicle registration book fees collected stand at Rs. 39.3 million, and other forest sector income Rs. 18.9 million, administrative fines and confiscation Rs. 28.7 million, arrears Rs. 25.3 million, disbursement refund Rs. 38.7 million, and other administrative fees Rs. 12.8 million.

GTC TO ORGANISE TOURISM HERO AWARDS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

Global Tourism Council (GTC) is organising Tourism Hero Awards in Nepal for the first time. The awards will be given in 31 different categories among individuals and organisations which have contributed to the promotion of tourism in Nepal.

According to the GTC, award trophies will be handed over to the winners in a ceremony to be held in Kathmandu on March 19. It is estimated that more than 500 contestants will compete in 14 hotel categories and 17 other tourism categories.

According to the organisers, anyone can file a nomination for themselves or others with detailed information by visiting the Tourism Hero Awards 2024 official website at TourismHero.org. Among the nominations received, the nominations with complete and official details will be shortlisted and made eligible for voting.

Based on the public vote received, the winner will be announced. This entire process will be web-based and free. Dharmendra Sapkota, Chairman of the GTC, said that this award is being organised with the aim of encouraging individuals and organisations involved in tourism and its promotion in Nepal.

The award categories include the best in travel agency (holiday/inbound), technology, CEOs, startup, journalism, entrepreneur, women entrepreneurs, branding and marketing, infrastructure, municipality and rural municipality, mayor and Tourism Hero.

Likewise, categories in hotel sector include best five/four/three star hotel, resort, boutique hotel, chain hotel, chef, chain restaurant, eco-friendly etc.

MASSIVE TOURISM INFRASTRUCTURES BEING BUILT IN BAGLUNG

RSS
Dhorpatan (Baglung), Feb. 14

The Gandaki provincial government has prioritized the promotion of the religious tourism sites lying in the lurch for years in Baglung district. In this connection, the Gandaki province's Ministry of Industry, Tourism, Forests and Environment has started constructing tourism infrastructures at 76 places of the district this year.

The Ministry has allocated Rs 64 million for developing the tourism infrastructures in all the 10 local levels in the district. These projects are being implemented through the Tourism and Industry Office Baglung. It is said among the 76 projects, 58 are under-construction after having concluded the contract agreement while 18 projects are in the contractual process.

The highest number of projects is in Baglung Municipality. The municipality has 20 such projects with a budgetary outlay of Rs 23.5 million, said Parasingh Thapa, the Chief of the Tourism and Industry Office Baglung. Similarly, Jaimini Municipality has 13 projects with a budgetary outlay of Rs 9.5 million, the Galkot Municipality has nine projects with an outlay of Rs 7 million and the Dhorpatan Municipality has four projects with a budget allocation of Rs 2.5 million.

Fifteen projects with an outlay of Rs 9 million are to be constructed in Kathekhola Rural Municipality, five projects are to be constructed at Badigad Rural Municipality with an investment of Rs 3 million and three projects are to be built in Nishikhola Rural Municipality at an estimated cost of Rs 3 million.

Likewise, Rs 3 million has been allocated for the construction of three tourism infrastructure projects in Tarakhola Rural Municipality, Rs 2.5 million has been allocated for developing three projects in Bareng Rural Municipality and Rs 1 million for construction of one project in Tamankhola Rural Municipality, Office Chief Thapa said.

Airbnb loses $349 million on Italian tax dispute

AP
Washington DC, Feb. 14

Airbnb said Tuesday that it lost $349 million in the fourth quarter due to an income tax settlement with Italy, but bookings and revenue rose, and the short-term rental giant said demand remains strong. The company forecast first-quarter revenue that would meet or beat Wall Street expectations.

However, the pace of bookings growth is likely to "moderate" from the fourth quarter into the first, and the early timing of Easter could hurt growth in the second quarter, Airbnb said. CEO Brian Chesky said on a call with analysts that Airbnb is "perfecting" its business — making pricing more transparent, reining in exorbitant cleaning fees, and reducing cancellations by hosts. Now it plans to go beyond its core.

Chesky said the company will build out its rental platform in countries where it isn't as strong as the United States. He said that is already underway in Germany, Brazil and South Korea, and will soon be tried in Switzerland, Belgium and the Netherlands.

"But this is only one piece of a much bigger strategy because we have always believed that Airbnb was destined to offer more than just a place to stay," he said.

Chesky, however, gave no details about the "multiyear journey," only promising news late this year. Rivals such as Vrbo parent Booking Holdings and Expedia Group also make money from things like flight and rental-car listings. The fourth-quarter loss compared with a profit of $319 million a year earlier. The recent results were dragged down by $1 billion in one-time tax withholding expenses and lodging tax reserves.

The vacation-rental platform disclosed in December that it would pay Italy's tax agency 576 million euros ($621 million at the time) to a case involving withholding from property hosts in that country. Airbnb not admit wrongdoing, and company officials say they don't fact any similar liability in other countries.

Excluding the special expenses, Airbnb said it would have earned $489 million. Revenue rose 17% to $2.22 billion, beating the $2.17 billion forecast of analysts in a FactSet survey. Bookings rose 12%, and the average daily rate gained 3%.

Karki elected chair of Nepal Trans Himalaya Border Commerce Association

RSS
Chautara (Sindhupalchowk), Feb. 14

Ramhari Karki has been elected as the new chair of the Nepal Trans Himalaya Border Commerce Association. The election took place during the Association's 24th Annual General Meeting (AGM) and 12th Convention, where Karki secured victory with 434 votes, defeating his competitor Lopsang Sherpa by 13 ballots.

Furthermore, Ganga Bahadur Ghimire (442 votes) and Ramchandra Parjauli (443 votes) have been elected as the two senior vice chairpersons for the Association. The newly elected secretaries on the committee include Bikash Prasad Rijal, Angdorje Sherpa, Tulasi Raut (Shyam), and Subba Shrestha. Other office-bearers including committee members were elected unopposed. The elections for positions where unanimous selections.

DHULIKHEL ZIPLINE ENTERS INTO 6TH YEARS OF OPERATION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

Dhulikhel Zipline has completed five years in the business of adventure sports. Established on February 14, 2019, this adventure product has garnered popularity, attracting not only common individuals but also high-profile government officials and prominent artists, the company said in a statement on Wednesday.

From Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' to various leaders and artists, including Bagmati Province Physical Infrastructure Development Minister Yuvaraj Dulal, National Assembly Speaker Ganesh Timilsina, Captain Vijay Lama, actors Pooja Sharma, Barsha Siwakoti and Anmol KC, comedian Manoj Gajurel, singer Rachana Rimal and Pratap Das have enjoyed the Dhulikhel Zipline operated by World-Wide Adventure Pvt Ltd.

Bhupesh Shrestha, CEO of Dhulikhel Zipline, said that the proximity to Kathmandu (at a distance of 35 km) and the availability of classic, superman, and tandem ziplines contributed to its popularity. It allows participants to capture photos and videos during their ziplining adventure for a fee of Rs 3,000. Similarly, Dhulikhel Zipline introduced Superman and Tandem Ziplines in Nepal. The 1,100-meter zipline, connecting Thakle in Dhulikhel Municipality to Khawa in Panchkhal, serves up to 100 people daily at an average speed of 75 km per hour. The journey begins from the top station, situated 1,300 meters above sea level, descending 100 meters to the bottom station.

Along the way, participants experience a 'vertical drop' of 240 feet, enjoying panoramic views of nearby farmlands, lush forests, and prominent mountains such as Langtang, Dorje Lakpa and Furbichu. Five years ago, Kedar Thapa of Sindhupalchok and Bhupesh Shrestha of Kathmandu invested approximately Rs. 70 million to bring this thrilling zipline project into operation.

9 gold mine workers missing in Turkey after a landslide

AP
Istanbul, Feb. 14

A huge landslide hit a gold mine in eastern Turkey on Tuesday, trapping at least nine workers underground, officials said. The landslide at the Copler mine happened at 2:30 p.m. near the town of Ilic in Turkey's mountainous Erzincan province. Footage seemingly shot by a nearby worker showed a massive wave of earth rushing down a gully, engulfing everything in its path.

Nine workers had not been heard from since the landslide struck and "it is thought that they are buried under the ground," Interior Minister Ali Yerlikaya said. The landslide involved a mound of soil extracted from the mine, Yerlikaya told urkey's state-run TRT News.

He said 400 search and rescue personnel were at the site. Turkish emergency agency AFAD said staff from surrounding provinces were brought in to take part. Erzincan Mayor Bekir Aksun, meanwhile, told broadcaster Haberturk that between 10 and 12 workers were missing. The Energy Ministry also put the number at nine.

Geologist Suleyman Pampal told Haberturk that the soil that formed the landslide had been processed for gold and may contain dangerous substances such as cyanide. He also warned of an environmental threat to the nearby Euphrates River. "Mixing with the Euphrates means the end of all life. It must be prevented urgently from reaching the Euphrates," Pampal said.

The Environment Ministry said in a statement that a stream leading to the Euphrates was closed to prevent water pollution. Erzincan Gov. Hamza Aydogdu said no cyanide had gotten into the waterway. "There is no leakage at the moment," he said. "If there were, we would explain it to you. There is no leakage into the Euphrates River. There was a landslide, so there is no problem other than this landslide."

The mine was closed down in 2020 following a cyanide leak into the river, which stretches through Turkey, Syria and Iraq. It reopened two years later after the company was fined and a cleanup operation was completed.

The Turkish government said social media content about the disaster that "has not been confirmed through official channels and whose accuracy is not assured" had been blocked. Anagold Mining has operated the Copler mine since 2009. Yerlikaya said 667 people were employed at the site.

Justice Minister Yilmaz Tunc said an investigation into the disaster had been launched. "I wish our citizens from Erzincan recover soon and hope that our miner brothers who are trapped under the rubble will be rescued safely," he said.

Turkey has a poor mine safety record. In 2022, an explosion at the Amasra coal mine on the Black Sea coast killed 41 workers. The country's worst mining disaster took place in 2014 at a coal mine in Soma, western Turkey, where 301 people were killed.

In the wake of those incidents, engineers warned that safety risks were frequently ignored and inspections not adequately carried out.

"The disaster that took place in Erzincan Ilic Copler gold mine is a disaster that (was) coming," the Union of Chambers of Turkish Engineers and Architects said in a statement issued on social media. The union added that it had filed two lawsuits against the mine's operation. "We said that Ilic Copler gold mine should be closed and rehabilitation works should be started."

Oil and gas producers to pay millions remedy for pollution

AP
Albuquerque, N.M., Feb. 14



A Texas company has reached a multimillion-dollar settlement with the federal government and the state of New Mexico to address air pollution concerns in the largest oil and gas producing region in the United States.

The agreement announced Tuesday with Apache Corporation calls for the company to pay $4 million in penalties and spend more than $5 million on preventative measures to reduce emissions at its wells in the Permian Basin, which spans parts of New Mexico and Texas.

Apache was accused in a civil lawsuit of failing to comply with federal and state requirements to capture and control emissions at some of its operations in the two states. Federal officials and regulators in New Mexico identified the alleged violations through field investigations and flyovers by helicopters outfitted with infrared cameras that can detect hydrocarbon vapors that are invisible to the naked eye.

Efforts by regulators to crack down on oil companies have ramped up in recent years through a combination of on-the-ground inspections, flyovers and now satellite imagery as they look for Clean Air Act violations across the Permian Basin and in other oil producing regions.

New Mexico Environment Secretary James Kenney said he's concerned about the compliance rate for companies operating in New Mexico, describing it as terrible. "The ozone levels are rising, and you know, I think this is that moment where we have to hold up the mirror to industry and say, 'If you don't like what you see, it's a reflection of your own effort," he said during an phone interview.

The civil complaint targeting Apache comes nearly a year after federal and state officials announced a similar agreement with another producer in the Permian Basin over violations. In 2022, an investigation by The Associated Press showed 533 oil and gas facilities in the region were emitting excessive amounts of methane.

Surveillance done by state and federal regulators in 2019, 2020 and 2022 turned up alleged violations at nearly two dozen of Apache's sites.

The company said in an email that the consent decree announced Tuesday resolves alleged violations from years ago and that the company acted swiftly to remedy the issues. Changes have included modifications to allow for more measurement, monitoring and capture of emissions and increased site inspections and expedited maintenance timelines.

"Moving forward, the consent decree represents our commitment to continuous improvement across our facilities in the Permian Basin," the company said. "We also continue to collaborate with industry partners through organizations such as the Environmental Partnership and the U.N.'s Oil and Gas Methane Partnership in striving toward a more sustainable future."

The agreement covers 422 of Apache's oil and gas well pads in New Mexico and Texas, ensuring that they will comply with state and federal clean air regulations and that past illegal emissions will be offset.

State and federal officials estimate that compliance will result in annual reductions of 900 tons of methane and more than 9,650 tons of volatile organic compounds, which contribute to smog. In all, state officials said the recent consent decrees with energy companies cover about 15% of oil and gas production in New Mexico and about 9% of the wells.

Tribhuvan University
Institute of Engineering
Entrance Examination Board

M.Sc. Entrance Examination Notice 2080

It is hereby notified to all concerned that Tribhuvan University, Institute of Engineering (IOE), M.Sc .computer based Entrance examination for the admission of students in constituent campuses for the academic session 2080/081 under different programs will be held from **29thFalgun 2080 (12thMarch 2024)**.

The candidates who have passed Bachelor degree in relevant area and willing to appear in the entrance examination to get enrollment into the M.Sc. programs should fill up and submit the Application Form online within the deadline prescribed by the Entrance Examination Board. Application forms will be available in the websites: **https://entrance.ioe.edu.np.** from**10:00 A.M., 6th Falgun 2080 (18th February 2024) to 3:00 P.M., 20th Falgun 2080 (3rdMarch 2024)**.

Additional information about the M.Sc. Entrance Examination 2080 can be obtained from the M.Sc. Entrance Examination Website https://entrance.ioe.edu.np on **5thFalgun 2080 (17th February 2024)**

Koshi to cover children's treatment cost: CM Karki

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gaighat, Feb. 14

The Chief Minister of Koshi Province, Kedar Karki, has announced that the provincial government will cover all the medical treatment expenses of children aged up to 10 years in the province.

Chief Minister Karki made this announcement while inspecting Udayapur District Hospital under the provincial government on Tuesday.

"Since all human beings are born naked, the Koshi Provincial Government has under my leadership prepared a budget to provide free treatment to all children in all 14 districts of the province without discriminating against them," CM Karki said.

On the occasion, Basanta Basnet, Mayor of Triyuga Municipality, and Dr. Gyanendra Jha, the Medical Superintendent of Udayapur Hospital, apprised the Chief Minister of the problems facing the hospital.

They highlighted the shortage of medical staff, ineffectiveness of the oxygen plant, and the need to upgrade the hospital's capacity to accommodate a significant number of patients.

In response, Chief Minister Karki provided a brief response, expressing the need to expand the hospital's capacity, extend the contract of service employees, and provide directives to the relevant authorities.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Karki, during the inauguration of the second provincial festival organised by Triyuga Industry and Commerce Association in Gaighat, said that industry was an essential component of the government. He said that poverty and unemployment could be alleviated only if young people were empowered to become entrepreneurs.

According to him, development is not solely about constructing physical infrastructure but also about nurturing skilled human resources. He highlighted the Koshi government's efforts in producing professionals such as doctors, engineers, lawyers and entrepreneurs. Furthermore, he mentioned that the government was providing scholarships to support the education of underprivileged children in the province, emphasising its commitment to this cause.

Chief Minister Karki asserted that the current government of Koshi province was established as per the country's constitution and has consistently adhered to the constitutional principles and procedures.



PHOTO: TRN

Chief Minister of Koshi Province Kedar Karki has announced that the provincial government will cover all the medical treatment expenses of children aged up to 10 years in the province.

Overload blamed for Palpa jeep accident

BY REKHIRAM RANA
Tansen, Feb. 14

The death toll in the Palpa jeep accident has reached 10 as of Wednesday afternoon. Eight of the passengers died on the spot in the jeep accident that took place at Chidisama in Tinaun Rural Municipality-6 of Palpa district on Tuesday evening. Two others died in hospital while undergoing treatment.

The ill-fated jeep with registration number La 1 Ja 2371 was heading to Chidisa from Dumre, according to Superintendent of Police of the District Police Office, Heramba Sharma. He blamed overload for the fatal accident. The jeep carrying passengers exceeding its capacity was climbing up a rough road on the hill when the accident occurred, added SP Sharma.

The jeep fell off some 300 metres down the road. As the vehicle could not carry the load uphill, it moved back and met the accident, said SP Sharma. Police said the jeep with the capacity to carry 13 passengers was carrying 26 and their goods. SP Sharma said the accident was the result of negligence on the part of the driver.

According to the police, 16 other passengers were injured in the accident. The deceased were identified as Yan Kumari Panta, 60, of Tinaun-6, Ram Bahadur Aslami, 39, of Tinaun, Krishna Bahadur Aslami, 67, and 29-year-old Urmila Aslami.

Similarly, Chandra Ranapal, 70, of Butwal Sub-metropolis-14, and his wife Chuna Ranapal, 60, also died in the accident, according to the information officer of the District Police, Sugandh Shrestha. Likewise, Gita Sunar, 20, of Tinaun-2, Bishnu Kala Kami, 66, of Ribdikot-1, Dil Kumari Sunar, 65, of the same place, and Dil Maya G.C., 29, of Devdaha Municipality-5, also died in the accident.

Police have said that seven children have also been injured in the accident. The injured children included Bidhya Sunar of Ribdikot-1, Maya Sunar, Aarav Sunar, Saurav Pun of Tinaun-6, Bibek G.C. of Khaireni of Rupandehi, Asmita G.C. and one unidentified two-month minor girl, according to Krishna Prasad Parajuli, Company Secretary of the Lumbini Medical College.

Further, Krishna Panta of Tinaun-6, Uma Rashkoti of the same place, Amrita Gahatraj, Shanti Rana, Kul Bahadur Nepali, Rama Sunar of Ribdikot-1, Bhumi Pun of Haraiya, Rupandehi, Dan Bahadur Chidi of Tanasen-10 and Kamala Sunar of Tinaun-2, were also injured. They were taken to the Lumbini Hospital for treatment.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Two childs initiating writing on the wall on the occasion of Basanta Panchami in Kathmandu on Wednesday. Children start writing letters at this day as it is customary to worship Saraswati to gain knowledge and wisdom in life.

50% income from Mayadevi Temple sought for local level

BY LAXMAN PAUDEL
Bhairahawa, Feb. 14

Locals have demanded that 50 per cent of the income generated from the offerings made at the Mayadevi Temple and other incomes of Lumbini be provided to the local government. Save Lumbini Struggle Committee recently submitted a 19-point demand to the Lumbini Development Trust.

Stating that locals have contributed to the development of the Lumbini Master Plan by providing their land, but the income generated is not invested in local development works, the committee has demanded that 50 per cent of the income of Lumbini Development Trust should be given to Lumbini Sanskritik Municipality.

The committee also demanded an amendment to the statute of LDT with a provision of appointing locals as the vice-chair, secretary, treasurer and two executive members of its board of directors.

Likewise, the committee has demanded that the Mayor of Lumbini Sanskritik Municipality, the federal lawmaker and Provincial Assembly member elected from the Lumbini area should be ex-officio members in the Lumbini Development Trust.

The committee has also demanded that the existing design and structure of Mayadevi Temple should not be altered, and the construction of unauthorised structures should be stopped. Similarly, the struggle committee has also demanded that arrangements be made for free entry to the Mayadevi temple.

It has also demanded sufficient budget and involvement of locals for the historic Chaitra Purnima Fair, giving priority to locals while appointing staff. It also demanded the operation of electric buses and vans targeting domestic and external tourists as soon as possible.

It has demanded the construction of a parking lot for small vehicles between gates no. 4 and 5, maintaining the southern entrance gate in its original place as it has its historical importance. The committee demanded that the International Assembly Hall should be brought into operation as soon as possible.

The committee also demanded an amendment to the statute of LDT with a provision of appointing locals as the vice-chair, secretary, treasurer and two executive members of its board of directors.

As mentioned in the master plan of the Lumbini Development Trust, the committee demanded the immediate construction of a school, a well-equipped hospital, and a garden within the Lumbini Development Complex. It also asked to maintain the spiritual atmosphere in Lumbini to continue the morning and evening worship and lamp lighting programme at the Mayadevi Temple, to keep the temple open from 5 am to 10 pm and to provide employment to the locals.

The Struggle Committee has also demanded that the vehicles should not be allowed inside the Lumbini Master Plan and more than 39 idols and valuable archaeological objects found during excavation in Lumbini so far should be restored in Lumbini.

Coordinator of the Struggle Committee, Ram Bikash Chaudhary, said that the memorandum submitted to the Lumbini Development Trust was sent to the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation and the Chief District Officer of Rupandehi.

NEPAL AIRLINES CORPORATION
CONTINUING AIRWORTHINESS MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT
Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal

Re-Invitation for Sealed Quotation
(International Competitive Bidding)
Date of Publication 15th February 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC), Continuing Airworthiness Management Department Invites Sealed Quotation from PT6A-27 Engine Repair/Overhaul Organization (MROs) for exchange of its two (02) PT6A-27 core engines. The MROs are encouraged to visit the Notice/Announcement page in NAC Website: www.nepalairlines.com.np for detail information and downloading the Sealed Quotation Document.

Completed Sealed Quotation document should reach to the address given below within 07 (Seven) days before 17:00 hours local time from the first date of publication of this notice. For further information, please contact:

Nepal Airlines Corporation
Continuing Airworthiness Management Department,
Tribhuvan International Airport
Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel: +977 1 4113085 / 4113209, Fax: +977 1 4470768
Email: dir.camd@nac.com.np, dydir.epd@nac.com.np
Website: http://www.nepalairlines.com.np *(Notice/Announcement page)*

International Competitive Bidding (ICB)

Invitation for bids for the supply of Chemical Fertilizer

Bid Identification No: STC/TN/U/2080/081/0008

1. 1. Salt Trading Corporation Limited **(STCL)** invites sealed bids (hereinafter called the "Bid") from eligible bidders, for the procurement of the following chemical fertilizer (hereinafter called the "Goods"):

Chemical Fertilizer	N:P:K	Quantity in Metric Tons	Shipping tolerance
Urea	46:00:00	30,000	+/- 2 percent

2. The following are the various timeline associated with the bid:

Tender details	Date	Time
First date of publication	February 15th, 2024	-
Purchase of documents	All working days within March 6th, 2024	Within 1200 hours
Last date of submission of technical documents	All working days within March 6th, 2024	Within 1300 hours
Opening of technical bid documents	March 6th, 2024	At 1400 hours
Publication of technically qualified bidders	March 10th, 2024	Within 1700 hours
Submission of financial bids	March 15th, 2024	Within 1300 hours
Opening of financial bids	March 15th, 2024	At 1400 hours

3. The bid documents will comprise of two documents: (i) the technical bid document, and (ii) the financial bid documents. Disclosure of the price offer in the technical document will render the bidder as disqualified and the entire submission will be treated as non-responsive.
4. The technical and financial bids shall be opened at the time as specified in clause 2 on this notice at the office of STCL, Kalimati, Kathmandu, Nepal. The Financial bids must be valid for a period of 21 days counting from the day of the financial bid opening.
5. Bidder must quote the price in United States Dollars for the supply and delivery of above-mentioned **Chemical Fertilizer** on CIP warehouses delivery price on all of the following delivery points that are STCL Biratnagar, Birgunj and Bhairahawa warehouse. In case the bidder is an entity of Nepal, they must quote as per the prevailing law of Nepal and the directive(s) of Central Bank of Nepal (Nepal Rastra Bank). For evaluation purposes only, the rate of exchange will be the selling rates officially prescribed by Nepal Rastra Bank and prevailing on the date of opening of the tender. Payments will be done in United States Dollars.
6. Bid applicant must have prior experience of having supplied a minimum of the bid quantity of any chemical fertilizer to Nepal or any other countries during the last three years. The experience eligibility criteria are mentioned in clause 14, section B of the technical bid document.
7. The tender document can be obtained upon payment of a non-refundable fee of NRs 10,000.00 (Nepali Rupees ten thousand only) in cash or in form of bank receipt (bank account available upon request) for fee in favor of Salt Trading Corporation Limited, Kathmandu, Nepal.
8. Eligible bidders (principal) or their authorized representative can purchase the two signed and endorsed tender document on or before the time specified in clause 2 of this notice from STCL, Central Office, Kalimati, Kathmandu, Tel: +977-1-5371014, 5371208 and 5382022, e-mail: stcnepal1963@gmail.com by submitting a written application. In case of foreign bidder, the application letter must be in the local representative letterhead along with notarized copies of the following documents: (i) company/firm registration certificate of local representative, (ii) VAT/PAN certificate of local representative, (iii) recent tax clearance certificate of local representative, and (iv) authority letter issued by the eligible foreign bidder stating their intention to participate in the tender and also authorizing the said local representative company and name of assigned person to purchase the set of tender documents on their behalf. In case the bid is by a Nepali company, then the application letter must be issued by the said company duly stating that they themselves are the eligible bidders. In such a case, the Nepali bidder must submit notarized copies of their (i) company registration certificate, (ii) PAN/VAT registration certificate, and (iii) recent tax clearance certificate. In case foreign companies register a joint venture (JV) with Nepali company for the purpose of bidding in this contract, the said JV Company will have to submit all documents as applicable for Nepali bidders as well as a copy of the JV agreement. Eligible Bidders may be a private entity, government owned entity or any combination of them with a formal intent to enter into a contract.
9. After evaluation of the technical bids, a list of the qualified bidders name will be published in the company's website www.stcnepal.com and the bulletin board of STCL head office within the time as specified in clause 2 on this notice.
10. All interested bidders can attend the pre-bid meeting organized by STCL at its Kalimati, Kathmandu premises at 1400 hours of March 4th, 2024 to discuss confusions in the tender documents, if any. In case corrections are to be made as a result of the discussion at the said pre-bid meeting, the same will be incorporated in an amended tender document. The bidders are expected to examine all instructions, forms, terms and specifications in the bidding document. Failure to furnish all information required by the bidding documents or submission of a bid not substantially responsive to the bidding document in every respect shall be at the bidder's risk and will result in the rejection of its bid.
11. If the last date of purchasing, submission and opening of the bids (both technical and financial bid) falls on a Nepal Government holiday or a last minute holiday declaration by the Nepal Government, then the next working day for each subsequent phase of the tender bid shall be considered. In such a case, the bid validity and bid security validity shall be recognized with effect from the original bid submission deadline.
12. Purchased bid documents will be valid only for specified principal supplier.
13. The Purchaser (STCL) reserves the right to accept or reject the bid and to annul the bidding process and reject all bids at any time prior to the award of the contract without assigning any reason whatsoever.

Salt Trading Corporation Limited
Central Office, Business Department, Kalimati Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel: +977 1 5371208/ 5371014
email: stcnepal1963@gmail.com I web: www.stcnepal.com

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

History repeats itself, first as tragedy, second as farce.
- Karl Marx

EDITORIAL

Ecosystem Restoration

Nepal is endowed with rich biodiversity. This is because of diverse topography, climatic zones and altitudinal variations. 86 per cent of its land consists of hills and high mountains, and 14 per cent the flat lands in the Tarai region. It covers only 0.1 per cent of the world's area but has over 3 per cent flora and 1 per cent fauna of the globe. According to National Trust for Nature Conservation (NTNC), around 208 mammals, 890 birds, 123 reptiles, 55 amphibians, 230 freshwater fish and 651 butterfly species are found in Nepal. People, animals and plants form an inalienable part of nature's ecosystem. But growing human activities have threatened rare species, plants and water resources. The habitat loss, poaching and illegal trade of animal parts, conflict between animal and humans and climate-induced disasters have brought multiple crises to the existence of plants and animal species.

This situation indeed calls for sustained efforts to conserve the country's unique biodiversity. It is not that there are no initiatives to protect it. Various national and international agencies, state mechanisms, conservationists and local communities are doing their best to save and grow the species and plants. Their commitment, hard works and campaigns have yielded positive outcomes. The UN Environment Programme (UNEP) and the Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) have recognised the Tarai Arc Landscape (TAL) as one of its seven World Restoration Flagships. It is the part of the UN Decade on Ecosystem Restoration that seeks to prevent, halt, and reverse the degradation of ecosystems on every continent and in every ocean. It is a matter of happiness that TAL has earned international acknowledgement, becoming a significant landscape-level conservation practice. This has further encouraged the concerned stakeholders to handle existing and new challenges facing forests, wildlife, and communities.

Spread over 24,710.13 square kilometres, the Arc Landscape stretches from the Bagmati River in the east to the Mahakali River in the west, covering six protected areas, four forest conservation areas, three Ramsar sites and several critical corridors. It is also transboundary region extending over 900 km from the Bagmati River, Nepal, in the east to the Yamuna River, India, in the west, covering an area of 51,002 square kilometres. According to a news report carried by this daily, TAL stands as a unique landscape where biodiversity is conserved, ecological integrity is safeguarded, and the socio-economic well-being of the people is secured. TAL intends to conserve ecosystems of the Tarai and Churia hills while addressing the economic and livelihood concerns of the indigenous and local people as per its 50-year vision.

Initiated in 2001, the Tarai Arc Landscape Programme has restored 66,800 hectares of forest, helped increase the population of rhinos from 409 in 2005 to 752 in 2021, and nearly tripled its tiger population from 121 in 2010 to 355 in 2022. The first 10-year TAL Strategy and Implementation Plan (2004-2014) focused to deal with conservation management issues so as to develop TAL as an ecologically functional landscape. The second Strategy and Action Plan (2015–2025) has built on the conservation successes to ensure TAL's socio-ecological integrity over the next decade and beyond. Nepal has now claimed the result-based payment of USD 45 million through REDD+. The TAL programme has enhanced nature-based tourism, homestays and green enterprises, benefiting the local community as well as supporting the national economy. This exceptional conservation practice must be emulated in other ecological zones of the country.

Privileged Story Of A Migrant

PAMELA CRUZ

The opportunity to study abroad is usually a privileged migration experience compared to others. However, migration is difficult. The process of adaptation and the anxiety that comes with migration are complex and unique to each person and context. It means leaving the familiar behind and facing a new world that needs to be learnt about and embraced.

From a privileged position, people decide to migrate in search of adventure, knowledge and new experiences to broaden their horizon and view of the world. This was the case for me. Since the USA is not far from Mexico, and I had the support of my family who could afford it, I had the opportunity to participate in an exchange programme in Florida during my last year of high school.

This experience expanded my perspective on the world and gave me the opportunity to improve my second language, English. As a teenager, I was lucky enough to be able to explore a different culture in a controlled and caring environment. After this experience, one of my personal goals was to do a Master's degree abroad. Initially, I thought of the USA and the United Kingdom as options to reduce the language restrictions.

Eventually, I applied for a scholarship from the German Academic Exchange Service (DAAD) to study in Germany as friends of mine were already studying there and encouraged me to give it a try. After looking at various options for scholarships, academic programmes and financial support, I sent my application to Ruhr-Universität Bochum and was given the chance to study abroad fully funded.

With many difficulties amidst the uncertainty the COVID-19 pandemic brought, I moved to Bochum, a city in western Germany, in September 2020. During the lockdown, I built a strong support network with my flatmates and fellow Master's students. I think it was a good idea for the university to accommodate all the students in one building: the Papageienhaus ("Parrot house"). We spent our days with distance learning via Zoom and shared meals.

When the restrictions were eased, I took the opportunity to visit friends in other cities. By getting to know and explore Germany, I fell in love with the country, its culture and people. I didn't plan to stay from the beginning, but in the end a part of me will always hold a special place for Germany. One month before completing my Master's degree, I got a job in Mexico. The decision to return home was not easy, but it was the right one.

Despite the challenges, I know that my experience of migrating and returning to my home country have been quite privileged. I am grateful for that. But I keep thinking that many don't have the same luck I had. I wish more people all over the world were given the same opportunities.

- Development And Cooperation

Democratising Party Leadership Essential



Mukti Rijal

Around the world, voters appear to be turning away from traditional political organisations. The latest election results in Pakistan indicates that the traditional dynastic political parties like Pakistan People's Party led by late Benazir Bhutto's scion Bilwal Bhutto Zardari and Pakistan Muslim League (PML) led by Nawaz Sharif have been downsized and humbled by the impressive show of Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party headed by cricketer-turned-politician, Imran Khan, in the polls held for 336-seat Pakistan National assembly, of which 226 are decided through direct voting.

Imran Khan is currently in jail in cases related to corruption and leaking state secrets. He led protests against the country's ruling dispensation after his shunting out from office in 2022. His conviction in a corruption case resulted in him being disqualified as a candidate. Moreover, Imran Khan's party has been denied election symbols, forcing the candidates to run as independents. According to reports, Khan maintains widespread popularity among Pakistan's largely young voters, who view him as a break from the political dynasties or military establishments that ruled the country for much of its independent history. In Pakistan, the Senate, the upper house of its parliament, has 100 seats. But unlike the National Assembly, the Senate is not elected directly. Its members are elected by the provincial assemblies. While the National Assembly (NA) has a tenure of five years, the Senate's tenure is six years.

Upsurge of independents

The Senate, the NA and the country's provincial assemblies combine to form the electoral college, which in turn elects Pakistan's president. In the current polls of the NA, as mentioned above, the independent candidates - adherents of Khan leadership - have emerged victorious in the larger number of the constituencies, beating their rivals from the traditional parties long ruling the country. It is almost clear that Khan's non-corrupt image and integrity was behind the impressive performance despite the much feared rigging and manipulation and on top that harassment of the ruling combinations. All odds were loaded against Khan and his party, but people's verdict blasted them to testify that his clean image and honesty had endeared him to the people, which led to harness their support in the polls.

Though Pakistan poll results alone cannot be alluded or generalised for the backsliding of the traditional political parties, there has been a global upsurge of the independents and new political formation characteried by the rise of the new alternative parties and leaders replacing the traditional parties and their obsolescent structures. Nepal is not an exception to it as new parties and independents have started to steal the political show, posing challenges to the traditional parties and leaders allegedly responsible for poor governance and weak development delivery. Though political parties are said to be the indispensable vehicles of democracy, they are blamed for failing to work to enhance and safeguard democratic values in accordance with the aspirations of the people.

The political leader who took cudgel against one's own party lambasting the Maoist party that he worked with as key ideologue and started a new political formation was Dr. Babu Ram Bhattarai. In 2015 Bhattarai had left the UCPN (M), and the following year he founded a new party called Naya Shakti Nepal (New Force Nepal). In 2019 he oversaw the party's merger with the Federal Socialist party Nepal, resulting in the formation of the Samajbadi (Socialist) Party Nepal. Ever since he left the Maoist party almost eight years ago and split with the Upendra Yadav-led Janata Samajbadi Party (JSP) two years ago, Bhattarai has been saying that the country needs a new force for the political, social and economic transformation of the country, arguing that such changes are not possible by the traditional parties.

> They are an important mechanism to link citizens with the state reforming parties and democratising leadership can restore the trust and confidence of the people.

Dr. Bhattarai leads Nepal Samajbadi Party (NSP) today, but this party is also under threat of split as one group within it is arguing for merger with the CPN-Maoist Centre. Dr. Bhattarai, as he admits, was not able to lend vigour and impart momentum to the new political force he had envisioned. But the country has several groups and bunch of leaders who indict the traditional political leaders and campaign for new and renovated version of politics and democracy. Both in hills and Madhes politics is being scripted anew with groups and leaders vying to take the centre stage to compete against traditional parties.

Katherine Ellison in her article titled "Can we have democracies without political parties" published in Knowledge Magazine (June 8, 2021) writes candidly with reference to the US: "The popularity of parties in America is at a nadir, with both the Democratic and Republican parties widely condemned as not only unrepresentative but also hijacked by elites. Indeed, a steadily increasing share of US voters identify as unaffiliated with either party. That proportion is now larger than the share of voters identifying with either Republicans or Democrats."

Direct democracy

Likewise, in Europe, for example, traditionally powerful centre-left parties are being accused of ignoring their voters, potentially contributing to a backlash that pushed the United Kingdom into Brexit. Political scholars have started to say that it's time to start visualising a more open and direct democracy, with less mediation by parties and professional politicians. Several trends have sped the declining popularity and power of the parties in the United States.

As argued by Katherine Ellison, the rise of independent political action committees in the US has given candidates a source of campaign funding outside the party channels that once dominated access to campaign money. This has made many candidates more entrepreneurial and less beholden to the party bureaucracy. The current global scenario thus indicates that traditional structuralist political parties across the globe have lost considerable goodwill and influence. However, as they are an important mechanism to link citizens with the state reforming parties and democratising leadership can restore the trust and confidence of the people.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

Facilitate FDI From Nepali Diaspora



Raj Maharjan



Dila Kharel

According to the 2021 census, 2.2 million Nepalis reside overseas. In the fiscal year 2022/23 Nepal received remittance of Rs 1220.56. What would be the impact on the economy if even a fraction of the overseas population invested in productive sectors in Nepal instead of merely sending money home? In most cases, the remittance is primarily used to pay off personal debt. One of the unintended consequences of the massive amount of cash flow into the market from remittance is that it is helping family members spend money on unproductive consumer goods, further exacerbating the already skyrocketing inflation.

What would the capital and investment market look like if part of the remittance were capital investment instead of being simply a passive and unproductive money transfer? From the principle of velocity of money, an investment framework will have a positive contribution to the GDP and add value to the economy more positively than that from an economically passive remittance model. FDI is a vast and complex issue.

Game changer

FDI from the global Nepali diaspora could be instrumental to attract capital in Nepal. The post COVID-19 global economic climate is already in a state of recession. Indicators are painting a potentially dire scenario for Nepal's economic future. In such a volatile economic outlook, FDI has potential to not only make a positive contribution but also to be a game changer to shift Nepal's economy significantly towards a more capital and investment ecosystem. In the past, there have been instances of FDI in Nepal from the Nepali diaspora community, albeit few and far between. What we are proposing here is a mass-scale FDI as a norm instead of a handful of exceptional cases.

On behalf of the global diaspora the authors of this article would like to request the Nepal government to convey, through a liberal FDI policy, a message to the wider global Nepali diaspora about its approach to welcome capital investment from them. We believe that such an approach will encourage positive action from all relevant stakeholders, most importantly from the potential expatriate investors.

An owner of an overseas based consulting company has been trying to invest through their sister company in Nepal. The owner, who is a member of the diaspora community, said that they have been going around in circles without being able to make any progress. "For years, we have bounced around from here and there, from this office to that desk. There are unnecessary and unreasonable barriers for consulting and engineering sectors to invest in the country. Out of sheer frustration, we have diverted our capital somewhere else," the owner said. Similar to the above described real-life case studies, acknowledging that there is a large list of barriers, a few key issues and solutions are outlined below.

The existing minimum investment threshold of Rs 20 million is a barrier to attract FDI, as are restrictions in certain sectors for investment and lack of clarity about the FDI in the Nepal Citizenship (First Amendment) Bill, 2079. Likewise, there are multiple layers of bureaucratic hurdles, cumbersome process to repatriate earnings and issues related to tax. To address these issues, it is necessary to revise the minimum amount threshold of FDI investment to Rs 10 million. Also necessary is removing all existing restrictions, except for sectors sensitive to national security, exclusively for FDI to encourage capital, talent and technology transfer.

> The diaspora is ready and is willing to collaborate with the government and the private sector to make a positive contribution towards uplifting the economy.

What's more, there must be clarity on FDI mechanism and options in the context of the new Citizenship Bill to give confidence to the potential investors that there are no uncertainty or barriers at the structural and legislative level. Besides, it is imperative to streamline and accelerate official processes and paperwork, to remove the existing barriers to repatriate earnings, and to initiate negotiations for dual taxation avoidance agreement and bilateral investment agreements with countries such as the USA, Japan, Australia and New Zealand from where there is potential of FDI flow.

Official statistics paint a poor outlook of Nepal's economy. Only a few weeks ahead of the festive season, the markets are relatively quieter. Large and small business houses have been saying for some time that business is bad. Business confidence is not encouraging. These are only the tip of the iceberg. It won't be an exaggeration to say that Nepal's economy seems to be heading towards a crisis. In the budget of 2022/23, it was revealed that there was a budget deficit of Rs. 400 billion in the previous fiscal year. It is obvious that the economy would do better with a bit of capital injection. The government's past FDI policies haven't so far yielded a significant amount of investment, barring a few exceptional cases.

Low confidence

The diaspora today is capable of and willing to help their home country in the capital investment sector. However, its confidence is at a dismally low level due to the existing investment ecosystem. If the government wants the community to make mass-scale investment in the country, cutting the existing red tape, streamlining the investment process, simplifying taxation, and ensuring a seamless repatriation of return on investment are good places to start.

To facilitate and advance the ideas discussed above, we think that a high-level committee of relevant stakeholders involving the government institutions, the Nepal-based business community and the diaspora business communities is the first essential step. This committee will conduct a due diligence and make recommendations for a road map to improve the FDI ecosystem to facilitate a better flow of capital as investment. Suggested members of this committee are representatives from all directly relevant ministries, line agencies, departments, Investment Board, Nepal Rastra Bank and representatives of the global diaspora investor community. The authors are willing to contribute and share ideas to such a committee. Provided a favourable environment and a supportive framework, capital flow is possible. The diaspora is ready and is willing to collaborate with the government and the private sector to make a positive contribution towards uplifting the economy.

(Maharjan and Kharel are active members of the diaspora Nepali community based in Auckland and Sydney respectively.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 15, 1974

Nepal Bank Resumes Its Transaction

Nepalgunj, Feb. 14: The Nepal Bank resumed its transaction on 12th February after five days of closure, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Maiwakhola's Commendable Job

This is in reference to the news report headlined *'Murrah buffalo bull brought in Taplejung'* published in this daily on February 13. This initiative undertaken by Maiwakhola Rural Municipality marks a significant step forward in enhancing agricultural practices and uplifting the livelihoods of local farmers.

The decision to introduce the advanced Murrah buffalo breed is a commendable effort to improve animal husbandry standards and increase milk production in the region. It is heartening to see local authorities collaborating with farmers to bring about positive changes that benefit the entire community.

By investing in high-quality breeding stock and leveraging funds allocated from its budget, the municipality has demonstrated a commitment to promoting sustainable agricultural practices and empowering



farmers. This forward-thinking approach not only enhances the productivity of the agricultural sector but also contributes to the overall socio-economic development of the district.

I look forward to seeing further progress in the agricultural sector in Taplejung.

Amrit Tamang
Sindhuli

TAILPIECE

A woman got on a bus holding a baby. The bus-driver said:"That's the ugliest baby I've ever seen." In a huff, the woman slammed her fare into the fare box and took an aisle seat near the rear of the bus.

The man seated next to her sensed that she was agitated and asked her what was wrong.

"The bus driver insulted me." she fumed.

The man sympathized and said: "Why, he's a public servant and shouldn't say things to insult passengers."

You're right." She said. "I think I'll go back up there and give him a piece of my mind."

"That's a good idea." the man said. "Here, let me hold your monkey."

Over 200 million Indonesians vote to elect president

AP
Jakarta, Indonesia, Feb. 14



PHOTO: AP

Electoral workers and a family member assist an elderly woman to dip her finger into ink to mark that she has already voted during the election in Solo, Central Java, Indonesia, Wednesday, Feb. 14, 2024.

Defense Minister Prabowo Subianto had a strong lead in an early, unofficial tally of Indonesia's presidential race Wednesday, suggesting the former general may be able to avoid a runoff.

The 72-year-old candidate has presented himself as an heir to immensely popular sitting President Joko Widodo, whose son he chose as running mate.

He's also a link to the brutal period of dictatorship that ended just over 25 years ago, when he served as a special forces commander in a unit linked to torture and disappearances, allegations Subianto denies.

Widodo's successor will inherit an economy with impressive growth and ambitious infrastructure projects, including the ongoing transfer of the nation's capital from congested Jakarta to the frontier island of Borneo at a staggering cost exceeding $30 billion.

The election also has high stakes for the United States and China, since Indonesia has a huge domestic market, natural resources like nickel and palm oil, and diplomatic influence with its Southeast Asian neighbours.

Widodo's rise from a riverside slum to the presidency has shown the vibrancy of Indonesia's democracy in a region rife with authoritarian regimes.

But with a leading candidate linked to a former dictator, and Widodo's son on the ballot, some observers fear that that democracy is eroding.

According to the early, unofficial tally conducted by polling agency Kompas Search and Development, Subianto had a 58% lead with 70% of the vote counted in polling places sampled.

The quick count is based on the actual vote count at a sample of polling stations across Indonesia. The official count may not be finished up to a month, but quick counts have provided an accurate picture of the results of all four presidential elections held in Indonesia since it began direct voting in 2004.

To avoid a runoff against his rivals — two former provincial governors, Anies Baswedan and Ganjar Pranowo — Subianto will need more than 50% of all votes cast and at least 20% in each of the country's provinces.

Indonesians voted on Wednesday in an election that took just six hours. The logistics of the vote across the tropical nation's 17,000 islands inhabited by 270 million people were daunting: Ballot boxes and ballots were transported by boats, motorcycles, horses and on foot in some of the more far-flung locations.

Aside from the presidency, some 20,000 national, provincial and district parliamentary posts were contested by tens of thousands of candidates in one of the world's largest elections, which authorities said concluded with no major problems. About 10,000 aspirants from 18 political parties eyed the national parliament's 580 seats alone.

Voters interviewed by The Associated Press expressed hope their next leader would help them achieve greater prosperity in a country where nearly a tenth of the population still lives in poverty.

"I hope Indonesia can progress better and that I did not vote for the wrong person," said Indra Nurohim, a 17-year-old high school student and first-time voter. "I hope we will have a better government."

The official vote tally is a laborious process that could take about a month, but early results based on sampling from registered private polling and survey groups are considered a reliable indicator of the final results. The presidential race will go to a runoff on June 26 if no candidate gets more than 50% of the votes.

Blasts hit natural gas pipeline in Iran

AP
Dubai, UAE, Feb. 14



PHOTO: AP

Flames leap into the air after a natural gas pipeline explodes outside the city of Boroujen in the western Chaharmahal and Bakhtiari province, Iran, in early Wednesday, Feb. 14, 2024.

Explosions struck a natural gas pipeline in Iran early on Wednesday, with an official blaming the blasts on a "sabotage and terrorist action" in the country as tensions remain high in the Middle East amid Israel's war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

Details were scarce, though the blasts hit a natural gas pipeline running from Iran's western Chaharmahal and Bakhtiari province up north to cities on the Caspian Sea. The roughly 1,270-kilometre (790-mile) pipeline begins in Asaluyeh, a hub for Iran's offshore South Pars gas field.

Saeed Aghli, the manager of Iran's gas network control centre, told Iranian state television that a "sabotage and terrorist" action caused explosions along several areas of the line.

There are no known insurgent groups operating in that province, home to the Bakhtiari, a branch of Iran's Lur ethnic group. Aghli did not name any suspects in the blasts.

Iran's Oil Minister Javad Owji, also speaking to state TV, compared the attack to a series of mysterious and unclaimed assault on gas pipelines in 2011 — including around the anniversary of Iran's 1979 Islamic Revolution. Tehran marked the 45th anniversary of the revolution on Sunday.

"The goal that the enemies were pursuing were to cut the gas in the major provinces of the country and it did not happen," Owji said. "Except for the number of villages that were near the gas transmission lines, no province suffered a cut."

In the past, Arab separatists in southwestern Iran have claimed attacks against oil pipelines. However, attacks elsewhere in Iran against such infrastructure are rare.

Since the revolution, Iran has faced low-level separatist unrest from Kurds in the country's northwest, the Baluch in the east and Arabs in the southwest.

However, tensions have risen in recent years as Iran faces an economy hobbled by international sanctions over its nuclear program. The country has faced years of mass demonstrations, most recently in 2022 over the death of Mahsa Amini, a young woman who died in custody after her arrest allegedly over how she wore her mandatory headscarf.

Meanwhile, Israel has carried out attacks in Iran that have predominantly targeted its nuclear program. On Tuesday, the head of the United Nations' nuclear watchdog warned that Iran is "not entirely transparent" regarding its atomic program, particularly after an official who once led Tehran's program announced the Islamic Republic has all the pieces for a weapon "in our hands."

Tensions over Iran's nuclear program comes as groups that Tehran is arming in the region — Lebanon's militant Hezbollah and Yemen's Houthi rebels — have launched attacks targeting Israel over the war in Gaza. The Houthis continue to attack commercial shipping in the region, sparking repeated airstrikes from the United States and the United Kingdom.

ISLAMIC STATE MILITANTS ATTACK BARRACKS, KILL 9 TROOPS IN SYRIA

AP
Cairo, Feb. 14

Militants from the Islamic State group attacked military barracks in central Syria this week, killing nine soldiers, an opposition war monitor said. The Syrian army and officials have not confirmed the attack.

IS claimed responsibility for the attack on Monday near the town of Al-Sukhna, saying its fighters also seized weapons abandoned by fleeing soldiers and set fire to the barracks. The militants' statement claiming responsibility was posted late on Tuesday.

The attack was the latest in intensifying clashes in the desert in eastern Syria between the militants and the Syrian army, supported by Iran-backed militias.

The Britain-based Syrian Observatory for Human Rights, a war monitoring group, says IS has carried out 41 attacks so far this year there.

The Observatory said three Syrian troops were wounded in addition to the nine killed in Al-Sukhna.

IS militants have found refuge in the desert in remote areas in Syria and along the Iraqi-Syrian border, where they continue to stage attacks nearly five years after the group was defeated in Syria in 2019.

Illegal border crossings from Mexico to US drop

AP
Washington, Feb. 14



FILE PHOTO: AP

Asylum-seeking migrants wrap themselves in plastic bags to ward off the wind and rain as they wait to be processed in a makeshift, mountainous campsite after crossing the border with Mexico, Friday, Feb. 2, 2024, near Jacumba Hot Springs, Calif.

Arrests for illegal crossings on the U.S. border with Mexico fell by half in January from record highs in December to the third lowest month of Joe Biden's presidency, authorities said Tuesday.

The sharp drop is welcome news for the White House, even if it proves temporary, as immigration becomes one of the biggest issues in this year's presidential election, with exit polls showing it is the top concern among many Republican voters in early primaries. House Republicans voted Tuesday to impeach U.S. Homeland Security Secretary Alejandro Mayorkas for his oversight of the border.

Seasonal declines and heightened enforcement by the U.S. and its allies led to the sharp decline, said Troy Miller, acting commissioner of U.S. Customs and Border Protection. U.S. authorities have repeatedly praised Mexico for a crackdown launched in late December.

Border Patrol arrests totaled 124,220 in January, down 50% from 249,735 in December, the highest monthly tally on record. Arrests of Venezuelans plunged 91% to 4,422 from 46,920 in December.

Numbers ebb and flow, and the January decline may prove tenuous. Panama reported that 36,001 migrants traversed the notorious Darien Gap in January, up 46% from December. The vast majority who cross the Panamanian jungle are Venezuelans headed to the United States, with considerable numbers from Haiti, China, Ecuador and Colombia.

"We continue to experience serious challenges along our border which surpass the capacity of the immigration system," Miller said.

Tucson, Arizona, was again the busiest sector for illegal crossings with 50,565 arrests, down 37% from December, followed by San Diego. Arrests in the Border Patrol's Del Rio sector, which includes the city of Eagle Pass, the main focus of Texas Gov. Greg Abbott's border enforcement efforts, plummeted 76% from December to 16,712, the lowest since December 2021. Arrests in Texas' Rio Grande Valley, dropped 60% to 7,340, the lowest since July 2020.

The only months of Biden's presidency with fewer border arrests were in June 2023, after pandemic-related asylum restrictions lifted, and February 2021, his first full month in office.

During an interview with The Associated Press in January, Mayorkas said that Mexico's immigration enforcement agency didn't have the funds in December to carry out enforcement actions but when that was rectified, there was an immediate and substantial drop in the number of migrants encountered at the southern border.

Greeks debating bill to legalize same-sex marriage

AP
Athens, Greece, Feb. 14



PHOTO: AP

A protester shouts slogans during a rally against same-sex marriage, at central Syntagma Square, in Athens, Greece, Sunday, Feb. 11, 2024.

Lawmakers begin a debate Wednesday on a landmark bill to legalize same-sex marriage that would make Greece the first Orthodox Christian country to do so.

The Valentine's Day session in parliament follows vocal opposition and protests from the church but also a shift in public opinion which — while still divided — is narrowly supportive of the reform.

If approved, the bill would grant same-sex couples full parental rights but not allow male partners to seek children born in Greece through surrogacy.

Here's a look at the reform and why it's happening now.

The journey toward legalizing same-sex civil marriage in Greece has been long and contentious, with governments in the past shying away from a confrontation with the Orthodox Church.

Civil partnerships for gay couples were made legal in 2015, with conservatives at the time opposing the initiative. Promises to extend those rights were repeatedly deferred as the country emerged from a severe financial crisis followed by the pandemic.

Many same-sex couples, meanwhile, chose to tie the knot in one of more than a dozen other European Union countries which already have marriage equality laws, bypassing restrictions they faced at home.

Early in his second term, centre-right Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis is currently pushing through a series of difficult reforms, that also include tackling fan violence in sport and controversially ending an official state monopoly on higher education.

The Greek church's opposition to the marriage bill has been emphatic.

The governing Holy Synod of senior bishops sent letters to all lawmakers outlining its objections. A circular with similar wording was read out during Sunday services at all Orthodox churches in the country, and religious groups have staged public protests against the proposal.

The church regards same-sex marriage as a threat to the traditional family model, arguing that support for that model could help address the declining birth rate in many European countries.

Support for that view in Greece has been expressed by other Orthodox countries, significantly including the Ecumenical Patriarchate which is based in Istanbul, Turkey.

Orthodox-majority countries, where churches take pride in continuity of tradition, are all located in eastern and southern Europe where public acceptance of gay rights has been broadly more apprehensive than in western Europe.

Campaigners for LGBTQ+ rights are calling the bill a milestone reform, as same-sex couples would for the first time be recognized as a family unit.

Partners who are not the biological parents of the couple's children would have to seek guardianship through adoption, which is more time-consuming than the process in many other European countries.

Transgender activists say they are likely to remain in legal limbo and are seeking additional changes to family law.

The political landscape surrounding same-sex marriage is complicated, but also offers a rare moment of consensus at a time when politicians across the European Union are keen to mark out their differences ahead of bloc-wide elections in June.

The Mitsotakis government is facing dissent from inside his own party and needs opposition votes for the bill to pass.

Many from the opposition are keen to back the reform. Stefanos Kasselakis, the opposition leader, last year became the first openly gay leader of a major Greek political party. Left-wing and centrist votes should provide a comfortable majority.

Political parties on the far-right are aligned with religious protests. They are unlikely to topple the bill but are seeking to draw support away from Mitsotakis' traditional conservative base of voters.

PRISM

Michigan man finds 70-year-old love letter

Michigan: A Michigan man is trying to solve the mystery of a 70-year-old love letter he found in a toolbox he purchased from a farm auction.

Rick Trojanowski of Grand Rapids said he bought the toolbox at a farm auction in 2017, but it wasn't until years later that he found an old letter stashed away in a drawer.

The letter was authored 70 years ago by Army Cpl. Irvin G. Fleming and was sent from San Francisco to Mary Lee Cribbs in Grand Rapids.

The letter featured Fleming apologizing to Cribbs for a disagreement they had, and professing his undying love and intention to marry her when he returns from the Army.

Pelican captured on Dutch golf course

Vught: A pink-backed pelican that escaped from a zoo in Belgium was captured after taking up residence at a golf course in the Netherlands.

The Den Bosch Animal Ambulance said the pelican had been spotted in various locations throughout the country in the week before it was spotted at the golf course in Vught.

Animal expert Jan Harteman was able to examine a ring around the bird's leg and used the information to determine it was both in Lithuania and lived in a Dutch zoo before being moved to a Belgian facility in 2019.

The pelican escaped from the zoo about two weeks ago and made its way to the Netherlands.

Animal Ambulance shared photos and video from the capture on Facebook.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

438 – Roman emperor Theodosius II publishes the law codex Codex Theodosianus
590 – Khosrau II is crowned king of Persia.
1637 – Ferdinand III becomes Holy Roman Emperor.
1764 – The city of St. Louis is established in Spanish Louisiana (now in Missouri, USA).
1870 – Stevens Institute of Technology is founded in New Jersey, US, and offers the first Bachelor of Engineering degree in mechanical engineering.
1879 – Women's rights: US President Rutherford B. Hayes signs a bill allowing female attorneys to argue cases before the Supreme Court of the United States.
1899 – Tsar Nicholas II of Russia issues a declaration known as the February Manifesto, which reduces the autonomy of the Grand Duchy of Finland, thus beginning the first period of oppression.

NC'S GAGAN SEES LACK OF COALITION CULTURE

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bharatpur, Feb. 14

Nepali Congress general secretary Gagan Kumar Thapa has said that coalition culture has not been developed in Nepal.

Speaking at a press conference held in Bharatpur on Wednesday, Thapa highlighted the necessity of clarity in both intention and operational style for successful alliances.

He pointed out the lack of dialogue and understanding among the political parties.

According to him, pre-election alliances only distort the democratic process and undermine the constitution's integrity.

Responding to concerns regarding the negative effects of pre-election alliances on Nepal's political system, he stressed the need to forge a post-election alliance.

According to him, pre-election alliances only distort the democratic process and undermine the constitution's integrity.

Stating that post-election alliances should be formed based on consensus, Thapa said that the current political landscape lacks the necessary clarity for effective collaboration.

Thapa also responded to inquiries about the Congress campaign's efficacy in addressing public grievances, acknowledging widespread disappointment among the citizens due to unfulfilled promises and delayed infrastructure projects.

Thapa said that while making investments in infrastructure development, there should be a proper understanding between planned initiatives and their timely execution, citing issues with the contract system as a contributing factor.

Thapa also shared insights gathered from his participation in the Mechi-Mahakali march, where he engaged with citizens to better understand their concerns.

He underscored the need for political parties to bridge the gap between expectations and reality, acknowledging the growing disillusionment among the populace.

Thapa's remarks came ahead of the Congress General Committee meeting, which is beginning in Lalitpur on February 19. As Nepal navigates its political landscape, Thapa's call for clarity and accountability resonates as a crucial step towards fostering a more responsive and effective governance framework.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Two girls buying roses for their loved ones on the occasion of Valentine's Day at a gift shop in Kamaladi, Kathmandu on Wednesday.

Modi opens stone-built Hindu Temple in UAE

AP
Abu Mureikha, UAE, Feb. 14

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited the Middle East's first traditional stone-built Hindu temple on Wednesday, internationalizing both his reelection campaign and his effort to push secular India into a Hindu state.

The trip to the BAPS Hindu Mandir just north of the city of Abu Dhabi capped Modi's whistlestop tour of the United Arab Emirates during which the Indian leader embraced the UAE's president, describing him as a brother and also spoke before a global leaders at a Dubai summit.

Modi is widely expected to win a third term as prime minister in the upcoming elections in India, the world's largest democracy.

But Modi's policies and his governing Bharatiya Janata Party have raised concerns over India's future, particularly for members of its Muslim minority as they have come under attack in recent years by Hindu nationalist groups.

That has made warming Indian relations with the Muslim-led Gulf Arab states crucial not only for India's energy security and for millions of its expatriate workers in the region, but also its international standing.



PHOTO: AP

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, left, waves as he walks with Hindu priest Brahmaviharidas Swami after arriving for the opening ceremony of the first stone-built Hindu temple in the Middle East, 40 kilometers northeast of Abu Dhabi on Wednesday.

Modi visited the temple in Abu Mureikha, built by the Bochasanwasi Shri Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha or BAPS, a worldwide religious and civic organization within the Swaminarayan sect. Modi has close ties to the organization.

Modi walked past the temple's seven spires, a nod to the autocratic UAE's seven sheikhdoms. He looked inside the temple, where earlier Wednesday a priest had consecrated the statues of deities, each worshipped by different Hindu denominations across India.

The prime minister waved at a crowd of thousands gathered of the event, described as a Festival of Harmony, some spilling out into overflow seating outside. Children greeted Modi, others cheered his movements through the temple with priests.

The temple effort extends back home for Modi as well. In January, he opened a Hindu temple built on the ruins of a historic mosque in the northern city of Ayodhya.

That temple is dedicated to Hinduism's Lord Ram and had been wanted by Hindus who describe it as restoring a religion suppressed by centuries of Mughal and British colonial rule. But the 1992 demolition of the mosque at the site trigged riots across India that killed 2,000 people, mostly Muslims.

Earlier Wednesday, Modi spoke before the World Governments Summit in Dubai, hosted by the city-state's ruler, Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum. Much of the speech could be seen as a stump speech on the global stage, describing his years in power as pushing for "minimum government, maximum governance."

SSB HALTS BUILDING CONCRETE STRUCTURE IN DASGAJA AREA

BY PREM ADHIKARI
Pashupatinagar, Feb. 14

Indian border security force (Sashastra Seema Bal) has stopped the construction of a concrete structure in Suryodaya Municipality-2, Ilam.

Disputes erupted between the securities of the two nations--the Armed Police Force of Nepal and SSB of India-- after the latter started constructing the concrete structure in the area between Junge border pillar numbers 70/2 and 70/3.

The Indian security forces agreed to stop the work after a dialogue was held among the locals, security officers from Nepal's side and the Indian security officials.

A few days ago, the SSB started constructing a guest house using cement, bricks, sand and pebbles in the location.

Ward chairman Dik Bahadur Bomjan of Suryodaya Municipality-2 said that the Indian side had unilaterally started constructing the concrete structure without consulting Nepali authorities. As soon as the municipality received information, it took the initiative to stop the work.

The Indian security forces agreed to stop the work after a dialogue was held among the locals, security officers from Nepal's side and the Indian security officials.

Bomjan said that the infrastructure built by the SSB lies in between the Dasgaja area, and the no man's land area, declared for the citizens of both the countries.

He said that SSB by developing a Google map and claiming that the area lies in India, had started building the concrete infrastructure without informing Nepal's officials.

Inviting an all-party meeting, the ward office has drawn the attention of the border administration and other government officials demanding a halt to the construction work permanently.

Chief of the Armed Police Force Ilam, Drona Bista, said that the Indian security officials agreed not to proceed with the construction work for now.

Earlier, the SSB had built a camp in the same place.

Ilam borders India stretching 52.5 km from Tiring in Rong Rural Municipality to Sandakpur Hill in Sanadkpur Rural Municipality.

Minister Saud...

They talked about the matters relating to providing passport and consular services to the Nepali community in New Zealand more conveniently and utilising the knowledge, expertise and skills of Nepalis residing in New Zealand for the benefit of the country.

Earlier in the morning, the second edition of the Nepal-New Zealand Foreign Ministry Consultation (FMC) was held between the senior officials of both Ministries. Rita Dhital, Joint Secretary, of South East Asia and the Pacific (SEAP) Division and Joanna Kempkers, Divisional Manager of South Asia and South East Asia of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Trade of New Zealand led their respective delegations.

The members of the Nepali delegation consisted of Kailash Raj Pokharel, Ambassador of Nepal and Komal Baral, Section Officer, SEAP Division, Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Nepal while from the New Zealand side, Mary Thurston, Unit Manager and April Kwak, Nepal Desk Officer of the South and South East Asia Division were the members of the delegation.

During the meeting, the two sides took stock of various aspects of bilateral relations and exchanged views on further promoting cooperation through enhancing economic and cultural engagements between the two countries, read the statement.

Minister Saud reached Wellington on Tuesday and was welcomed at the airport by officials of MFAT of New Zealand, Honorary Consul of Nepal to New Zealand Dinesh Khadka, and the representatives of the Nepali community.

The Nepali delegation is scheduled to return to Kathmandu, after concluding the visit of Australia and New Zealand, on Thursday.

Baitadi's 2-km ring road fails...

Pushkarraj Joshi (Lakhkhabhai), the Mayor of the Municipality, announced that he has prepared a detailed study report (DPR) worth Rs. 30 million for the ring road and has formally submitted it to the intensive urban development department. According to Joshi, "The municipality has drafted the DPR and forwarded it to two or three agencies for the construction of the ring road and Chela-Durgabhawani road.

However, the city lacks the internal resources to complete these projects. Intensive Town Development Committee has expressed interest in undertaking the construction of the ring roads, and we are optimistic that the budget will be secured within this year."

Police seize server of four cooperatives...

The list of individuals absconding includes- GB Rai, his brother Bhupendra, current chairman and manager Than Bahadur Budha, director Dheeraj Kumar Das, Hemanta Adhikari, Manoj Nakarmi, Suraj Shrestha, Aisma Gurung, Kabita Tamang, Sagar KC, Dinesh Roka, Lalita Tamang, account officer Srishti Manandhar and Loan Officer Buddhi Gurung.

In addition, the police are investigating the involvement of Rabi Lamichhane, President of RSP, and Dipesh Pun, son of former Vice President Nanda Bahadur Pun, in the same case.

Allegedly, over 19,000 depositors of Surya Darshan Cooperative have been defrauded of more than Rs. 1.35 billion. The investigation continues to unfold the layers of this cooperative scandal, implicating key figures in the process.

Group leaders suggest changing party's...

Parsuram Ramtel suggested organising the party's unity, internal evaluation and nomination and arranging provisions to take caste-based discrimination seriously. He also suggested changing the election symbol of the party and making arrangements to include Nepalis from around the world.

Bamdev Chhetri suggested making legislation clearer and empowering provincial and local party committees to make them executive. He proposed creating a disciplinary committee chaired by a party ideologue, not just party members.

Hariraj Adhikari proposed changing the election symbol and creating conditions for party membership after obtaining citizenship. He suggested empowering the commission and making all party committees smaller and clearer.

Ranjit Tamang presented the suggestion that the party statute should be passed and implemented from this convention and said that the commission should be made active. He suggested that the government and the party should be formed as a coordination committee.

Jhakku Prasad Subedi said that the preamble should be written to go for scientific socialism and caste-based discriminations should be taken seriously. He also suggested the arrangement for party membership after obtaining citizenship and removing the standing committee.

Nirmal Acharya suggested for arrangements for party membership online and to make the party technologically equipped. Stating that there was no need to mention the standing committee in the statute, he proposed making a party protector committee.

Om Sharma suggested making preambles stronger and changing the party's name, mentioning the need for direct elections. He proposed making all committees clearer, including the central one and creating a transparent party and a party-controlled government.

The participants of the statute convention were divided into 20 groups for collecting suggestions.

The remaining seven groups are expected to present their suggestions on Thursday.

NEA opens PPA for hydel projects...

The present provision will increase the capacity of the project and make it easier for the projects to raise investment.

Limit of solar energy increased

The Authority has increased the limit of PPA to be done with solar hydropower projects. The NEA has been making PPA of solar projects through competition.

The NEA will sign PPA of solar energy on the basis of competition within the limit of 10 per cent of the total capacity of the national grid, which will include the existing connected capacity and the projects that have already had PPA.

Earlier, the PPA of solar projects was limited to 10 per cent of the connected capacity of the national grid.

A maximum base rate of Rs. 5.94 per unit has been fixed for the purchase of solar power through competition. The PPA will be done with the project that bids less than the said rate in the competition.

"According to the new arrangement, PPA of about 800 megawatt solar projects can be done, we will make a competition for PPA of solar projects built near the 200 kV, 132 kV and 33 kV substations of the NEA," he said. "Hydropower projects will take some time to build, but solar projects will come within a year and a half, so solar energy connected to the grid has been given priority to meet the growing demand for electricity in winter."

The Authority has done PPA of 175 MW so far through competition. Out of that, 106 megawatts have been brought into operation. Additional 30 MW solar projects are in the process for PPA, said the NEA.

Four arrested on charge of defrauding over Rs. 77 million

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

Four persons have been arrested on the charge of defrauding Rs. 77.7 million in the name of transporting gold ornaments abroad.

The Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office arrested the accused on February 12 from different places.

Among those arrested include 33-year-old Kumar Thapa of Bhumlu Rural Municipality-3 in Kavrepalanchok, 42-year-old Mina Damai of Putlibazaar Municipality-4 in Syangja, 43-year-old Rabin Kumar Thapa of Golanjor Rural Municipality-4 of Sindhuli and 39-year-old Dilip Kumar Labh of Saptari Municipality-6.

According to the Superintendent of Police and Spokesperson for the Crime Investigation Office, Rabindra Regmi, Kumar Thapa has been accused of defrauding Rs. 20 million. Mina has been arrested on charges of banking offence and fraud of Rs. 36.5 million, Rabin Kumar of Rs. 26 million and Dilip Kumar of Rs. 10. 1 million.

Police investigations have shown that the group had first time bought genuine jewellery worth Rs. 1 million from a jewellery shop in Pokhara. Later, it bought jewellery worth Rs. 2 million for the second time, and worth Rs. 5 million for the third time. By doing so, they won the trust of the shop. But later, they fled by giving a payee cheque of Rs. 18 million to the jewellery shop," SP Regmi said.

In another crime, Dilip Kumar Labh, one of the members of their group, absconded after taking Rs. 2.6 million from a person in Sudal of Bhaktapur, saying that his group would provide 12 Anas of land to the owner of Pariwar Automobiles, Bhaktapur.

Similarly, in Chitwan, police said that they had cheated Rs. 13.6 million from some land entrepreneurs in the name of providing land in Chitwan.

There are two cases against them in Kaski district, four in Chitwan and three in Kathmandu, according to SP Regmi.

An orange tree can store up to 23 kg of carbon: study

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhankuta, Feb. 14

A study has shown that an orange plant can store up to 23 kg of carbon annually. Agricultural scientists from the National Orange Breeding Research Programme in Dhankuta have measured the carbon storage capacity of the orange tree.

In a study conducted by a group led by Dr. Umesh Acharya, an agricultural scientist, it has been discovered that one orange plant, over a period of eight to 50 years, can store up to 23 kg of carbon annually. The study was conducted on orange trees of different ages.

Acharya also said that they have started measuring the carbon storage capacity of citrus fruits, along with other sour fruits. This marks the first instance of such measurement for citrus fruits. Currently, fruits of different varieties are grown on around 200,000 hectares of land.

Of this, 49,000 hectares are dedicated to cultivating sour fruits such as oranges and lemons. Similarly, a total of 26,000 hectares of land is used to grow only oranges.

A legend of folk song Haridevi Koirala

By Govinda Marasini



Haridevi Koirala, an affluent figure in Nepali folk music, embarked on her formal musical journey for the first time with the song 'Paina Khabara' in 1985.

When Koirala created this song, she never anticipated becoming a singer.

However, the song led her to fame, establishing Koirala as a noted figure in folk music.

Born in Baidam, Kaski, in 1959, Koirala was drawn to music from an early age.

Born in a big family with five brothers, her house once consisted of around 40 members. She had responsibilities to look after, play with, and have fun with her brothers and sisters.

She completed her SLC from Barahi Secondary School in Pokhara.

Haridevi's exposure to the musical atmosphere in Baidam, where farmers sang while threshing corn, paddy, and millet, influenced her deeply.

At a young age, she began writing and reciting songs and poems. The folk tunes and sarangi performances of 'Gandharvas' at home further fueled her musical passions.

Koirala stated that she received immense support for her musical journey from her husband, Ram Bahadur Koirala.

She came to Kathmandu to record songs at Radio Nepal.

With the help of the artist Prem Raja Mahat, she managed to record a song in an ordinary studio.

After recording the song, she returned to her village, where it was decided that the cassette should only be released if her voice sounded good.

Two months later, she knew that the record had been released, and by then, discussions about the song were already ongoing. She had not anticipated the song's popularity.

Talking about her perspective on folk songs, she said that the simplicity and relatability of folk songs can deeply impact the public.

However, she expresses concern about the current state of many songs, noting a loss of the distinct rhythm, thematic richness, original fragrance, and precision in traditional songs.

She expresses concern that if the current trend continues, the younger generation may lose touch with the cultural and identity aspects of Nepali folk songs, putting them at risk of disappearing.

She said, "Folk songs are Nepal's indigenous music, let's study and not forget them. Folk music is the mother of music, and if its roots are disturbed, it will vanish."

Her musical repertoire covers a wide range of themes, including the pain of mothers, the joy of sisters, the struggles of marriage, stories of trafficked girls, the anguish of fathers, reflections on going abroad, human rights and the dowry system.

In addition to folk songs, she has ventured into Ratayuli songs, hymns and cultural songs.

Some of her notable compositions include 'Paina Khabara,' 'Chautarima Barko Chhaya Chaa,' 'Hitko Maya,' 'Peepalko Chhayale,' 'Phulko Dalima,' 'Aadhinkhola Syangja Bazar,' 'Choli Vijyo Ashunle,' 'Laali Jowan Kalile,' and more.

Koirala has penned and created over a thousand songs.

She particularly enjoys the storytelling aspect in her songs and believes they resonate with the rural, portraying the happiness, sadness, and empathy found in village life.

Rich in melodious voice and poignant lyrics, Koirala has remained steadfast in her dedication to art, literature, and music, staying loyal to her country and people.

Beyond her musical contributions, she has actively participated in various social sectors and excels in collecting and publishing old songs.

Now at 63, Koirala has 10 collections of songs, poems, and child songs to her credit.

Currently, she is engaged in remaking her old songs, with a recent release of a new video for her first song, 'Paina Khabar,' and plans to release 21 remade songs gradually.

(Marasini is a freelance journalist)

Salina: Yoddha Rajkumari to be released on March 29



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

The release date of the first Nepali animated film, 'Salina: Yoddha Rajkumari,' has been announced on the occasion of Saraswati Puja.

Releasing a poster on Wednesday, the production team also announced the release date of the film. The film is set to hit local theaters on March 29.

Presented by Rainmakers Animation Academy, the film is a fantasy film made entirely with Nepali technology and in the Nepali language. No other physical characters have been used except for the background voice.

As its main audience is mostly from multiplexes, it is going to be released in such theaters in the first phase and gradually increase its shows in other single theaters as well, informed the production team. Directed by Tejas Raj Joshi, the film is produced by Tejas Raj Joshi and Shruti Shrestha.

Shiv Puri and Shruti Shrestha handled the editing, with Sagin Maharjan, Abinash Singh Tharu, and Shirbha Manandhar contributing as graphic artists in the film.

Achin Sundar Pradhan has handled the technical work of information technology and networking of the movie.

The film tells the story of Princess Salina, who, along with others, embarks on a journey, including various trainings, to defeat the biggest demon.

Rainmaker Animation Academy is an animation and visual effects academy in Nepal located in Balaju, Kathmandu, which has been providing 3D animation and visual effects training for the past 10 years.

Now the academy has taken a step into film production and is planning to produce other films in the future as well.

Benisha Khatiwada, Aditi Gyawali, Ajme Kuinkel, Jharana Rai, Tejasraj Joshi, Sushil Nepal, Dev Neupane, Shiv Puri, Yubin Pujari, Juna Thapa, Kumar Neupane and others are the voice actors in the film.

Disneyland's Mickey Mouse and Cinderella performers may unionise

AP
New York, Feb. 14



Workers who help bring Disneyland's beloved characters to life — including Mickey Mouse, Donald Duck and Cinderella — are looking to unionise.

Labour organisers announced the campaign Tuesday, saying performers want better safety conditions and scheduling policies to help them keep the magic alive for visitors.

While most of the more than 35,000 workers at the Disneyland Resort in Southern California already have labour unions, about 1,700 performers in parades, character actors and support staff do not.

Union membership has been on a decades-long decline in the United States, but organisations have seen growing public support in recent years amid high-profile contract negotiations involving Hollywood studios and Las Vegas hotels. The National Labor Relations Board, the federal agency that protects workers' right to organise, reported more than 2,500 filings for union representation during the 2023 fiscal year, the highest number in eight years.

Disney operates two theme parks — Disneyland and Disney California Adventure — and a shopping and entertainment area called Downtown Disney in Anaheim, California. Disneyland, the company's oldest park, was the second-most visited theme park worldwide in 2022 with 16.8 million people coming through the gates, according to a report by the Themed Entertainment Association and AECOM.

Union cards were circulated starting last week to promote forming a labour union under the Actors' Equity Association, which traditionally represents actors and stage managers. The group already represents theatrical performers at Walt Disney Co.'s Florida theme parks, organisers told The Associated Press.

Actors' Equity officials declined to say how many cards were returned but said they hoped to collect them from more than half the performers, which would let them ask Disney to voluntarily recognise the union rather having to seek a vote through the National Labor Relations Board. They expect the process will take weeks.

Disneyland officials said in a statement that they believe cast members deserve the right to a confidential vote.

Those who want to form the union, which they are calling "Magic United," are seeking to address safety issues in costuming, such as keeping items clean and using appropriate fabrics for high-intensity dancing.

They also want more stable scheduling. The group began organising over health and safety concerns that arose when the park started allowing visitors to interact closely with characters again after the pandemic shutdown, Shindle said.

Some performers are also concerned about being asked to wear tights and make-up that don't match their skin tones, erratic and unpredictable staffing and fair pay.

Still, they said they relish working at the parks, where they play a unique role in creating the Disney experience, union officials said.

The union has advised California workers not to speak on the record about unionising, said David Levy, an Actors' Equity spokesperson.

JAAFAR JACKSON RECREATES KING OF POP'S DANGEROUS TOUR IN 'MICHAEL'

AGENCIES
Los Angeles, Feb. 14

The eagerly anticipated Michael Jackson biopic, "Michael," has just unveiled its first poster, offering a stunning recreation of one of the late singer's most iconic looks.

Jaafar Jackson, Michael Jackson's nephew, steps into the role of the King of Pop in "Michael," slated for release in theaters on April 18, 2025. Currently in production, the film promises a captivating exploration of Michael Jackson's life.

In the released photo, Jaafar Jackson takes center stage, flawlessly embodying his uncle's renowned "Man in the Mirror" appearance from the Dangerous Tour of 1992-93. The image, captured by photographer Kevin Mazur, who documented Jackson's career extensively, including during his "This Is It" rehearsals, showcases Jaafar's uncanny resemblance to the pop legend.

Producer Graham King lauds Jaafar's portrayal, stating, "With Jaafar, every look, every note, every dance move is Michael. He embodies Michael in a way that no other actor could."

The film's logline promises audiences an immersive journey into the life of the complex yet brilliant figure who ascended to become the King of Pop.

It pledges to depict Jackson's triumphs and tribulations on a grand cinematic scale, offering insight into his personal struggles alongside his unparalleled creative genius and iconic performances.

Badri Binod Prateek awarded

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Birgunj, Feb. 14



Badri Binod Prateek, a journalist from Kaski, Pokhara, has been awarded the Gotame Journalism Award this year.

The award is established by the Journalist Gopal Chandra Gautam Foundation in memory of Gopal Chandra Gautam, a journalist from Birgunj.

In a programme held in Biruanj on Wednesday, Mayor Rajeshman Singh of Birgunj Metropolitan City honoured journalist Badri Binod Prateek with a gold medal.

Jagadish Sharma, President of the Journalist Gopal Chandra Gautam Foundation, said that the foundation annually honours one of the best journalists with a gold medal and encouraged everyone to engage in honest journalism based on truth and facts.

Mayor Singh also expressed the metropolis's readiness to collaborate in the interest of journalists and the development of journalism, urging everyone to practise journalism based on facts.

Upon receiving the award, journalist Badri Binod Prateek said that he felt a sense of added responsibility along with the honour.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: An argument with friends or on social media could escalate out of hand without warning. As potent Mars meets earth-shaking Pluto in your 11th House of Community, you may see standing up for yourself as necessary for your self-worth!.

Taurus: Getting locked into a dramatic showdown with a gratuitously cruel authority figure is a risk now. As the delicate Moon moves into your sign, you could be the perfect foil for this character -- you can really.

Gemini: Pushing your political or spiritual views on others could be appealing to you today. Perhaps this seems easier than addressing your own doubts. If no one else ever asks inconvenient questions, then you won't be tempted to do so either.

Cancer: Someone could seem to be invading your turf at the moment. After the perceptive Moon shifts into your social 11th house, asking your friends for their view of the situation may help. You shouldn't necessarily follow their advice blindly.

Leo: A current power struggle in a close relationship could be more complicated than it appears. While the vulnerable Moon in your visible 10th house goads underhanded Pluto in your partnership zone, the person who makes the biggest emotional display may not truly.

Virgo: Working hard can bring you rewarding results at this time. The only thing capable of holding you back could be your beliefs about your responsibilities. As the sensitive Moon in your philosophical 9th house clashes with driven Pluto in your 6th House of Work.

Libra: You're ready to advocate for your own pursuit of pleasure -- particularly if this desire has been suppressed for far too long. Now that it's roaring out in full force with passionate Mars and intense Pluto united in your self-absorbed 5th house.

Scorpio: Someone else's objections could frustrate your current plans to improve your living space. Perhaps you're having trouble hearing what their complaint is, because your mind goes directly to other times when you've had to defer.

Sagittarius: Coming on too strong in conversation is an ongoing risk. While the impulsive Moon in your 6th House of Responsibilities aggravates domineering Pluto in your communication sector.

Capricorn: Using money to throw your weight around could be tempting you. While motivated Mars and mastermind Pluto conspire in your 2nd House of Resources, you probably aspire to feel powerful and in control of a situation.

Aquarius: Making yourself look big and scary can help you feel safe at present. As assertive Mars and rooted Pluto meet in your sign, you're equipped to cast an intimidating presence.

Pisces: YTearing your perceived opposition down behind their backs could seem justified at the moment. As aggressive Mars meets vindictive Pluto in your subversive 12th house, the larger problem is probably.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





CWC League 2 begins today

Nepal, Netherlands and Namibia determined to start with wins



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

The Netherlands, Nepal and Namibia are three of the best Associate teams in international cricket and the trio is kicking off the four-year cycle of 24 tri-series under ICC CWC League 2 (2024-2027) on Thursday (February 15).

The trio, who is also playing in the T20 World Cup in June, stressed that they want to start the League 2 campaign with wins.

Speaking at the pre-match conference in Kathmandu on Wednesday evening, Gerhard Erasmus, captain of the Namibian side, said, "We start an interesting four years of cricket ahead. We have trained properly and prepared for this. We will bring Namibian culture to Nepal."

According to Namibia's coach Pierre de Bruyn, he is happy returning to Nepal after almost a year. "We are very happy to be back in Nepal. Our group is confident. It is going to be a competitive series between three good teams and we are looking forward to it," he said.

The Dutch side seemed more confident in the conference as the team was travelling to Nepal after bagging some good wins in the 2023 World Cup.

"We have had success in the one-day format of late and we look to continue the form in the tri-series," said Scott Edwards, captain of the Netherlands.

Similarly, Ryan Cook, coach of the Dutch team, expressed joy in playing in Nepal. "There will be challenges, but the team has prepared for it. We see the matches against Nepal and Namibia as final touches for our preparation for the T20I World Cup."

Nevertheless, the Nepali side was the most confident one as the team is formidable on the home soil while playing in front of the home crowd.

"The series against Canada was important for us because we needed a good preparation for the League 2 matches. We did not start the League 2 campaign properly in 2019 due to which we struggled in the final year (2023). This time, we will start League 2 properly and the team is excited about it," said Rohit Kumar Paudel, captain of the Nepali side.

Stressing how tough the journey of an Associate member in the cricket world is, Nepal's coach Monty Desai said, "Starting well is important in the league which expands for four years."

Desai added, "The clean sweep against Canada was a result of work put in place as the domestic tournament helped a lot for preparation. Now, we face two quality sides – Namibia and the Netherlands. Moreover, the Netherlands has been the flag bearer for the Associate members in the World Cups and the competition will be great."

The three teams are among the eight teams in League 2. The eight teams will face each other in 24 tri-series in four years and the top four teams at the end will progress for the 2027 World Cup qualifiers.

Nepal's squad amended

The Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN) made public the squad of Nepal to face Namibia and the Netherlands before the bilateral series with Canada.

However, the CAN made some amendments to the earlier squad on Tuesday evening.

When asked about the reason behind the change in the squad in the final moments, coach Desai said, "If the change in the squad is in the interest of the team, it is not a headache but good work."

As per the final squad, Rohit Kumar Paudel is leading the team comprising Aasif Sheikh, Kushal Bhurtel, Kushal Malla, Anil Kumar Sah, Aarif Sheikh, Pawan Sarraf, Bhim Sharki, Dev Khanal, Dipendra Singh Airee, Gulshan Jha, Sompal Kami, Karan KC, Lalit Narayan Rajbanshi and Surya Tamang.

Nepal-A team revealed

The Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN), on Wednesday evening, made public the 16-men 'A' team of Nepal.

Revealing the 2024 cricketing calendar in January, CAN's secretary Paras Khadka said, "We are forming our A team. The team will contain out-of-form players, emerging U19 players, new talents and inactive internationals in form. It will allow the players to improve their game and earn a spot in the national men's team." After around a month of the declaration, the A team has finally been formed.

Former national team player and captain Gyanendra Malla and Kalam Ali have been assigned the coaching responsibility for the A team. Malla recently completed the ICC Level 2 coaching course in Singapore as the best among the participants.

Binod Bhandari is making his comeback to international cricket as the captain of the A team. Other players in the squad are Ashutosh Ghiraiya, Arjun Kumal, Bashi Ahmed, Bibek Yadav, Hemant Dhami, Kiran Thagunna, Mayan Yadav, Pratish GC, Rashid Khan, Sagar Dhakal, Shahab Alam, Sundeep Jora, Sher Malla and Sujan Thapaliya.

ACC Women's Premier Cup

Nepal thump Kuwait, faces host Malaysia in semi-finals

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 14

The ACC Women's Premier Cup semi-finals on February 16 will see four teams, who have progressed without losing a single match, vying for a place in the finals. The two finalists will qualify for the Women's Asia Cup in July 2024.

Toppers of four groups, Thailand, UAE, Malaysia and Nepal, have qualified for the semi-finals after winning their respective quarter-final matches against second-positioned teams of the opposite groups on Wednesday.

Group A topper Thailand defeated Hong Kong, Group D's second team, while Group B topper UAE bested Indonesia, Group C's second team.

Similarly, Group B's second-positioned Japan lost to Group C topper Malaysia while Group D topper Nepal defeated Kuwait in the only quarter-final match affected by rain.

Electing to bat first, Kuwait played all 20 overs but failed to cross the 100-run mark. The team was able to post a paltry target of 74 runs in the loss of nine wickets.

The player of the match, Sita Rana Magar, bagged a hat-trick while Kabita Kunwar and Rubina Chhetry claimed two each for Nepal.

Sending opener Priyada Murali back to the pavilion in 12.2 overs, Maryam Omar and Kuwati's captain Amna Tariq were stumped and struck leg-before in the third and fourth balls of the 13th over by Sita respectively.

Priyada (29 off 33) was the highest scorer for Kuwait followed by a 13-run contribution each by Balasubramani Shanti and Khadija Khalil. None of the other batters was able to reach the double figures for Kuwait.

Nepal's chase started late due to an interruption by rain. Officials resumed the match by revising the target for Nepal to 50 runs in 12 overs. It only took Nepal seven overs to chase the target and enter the semi-finals.

Losing opener Kabita Kunwar (1 off 4) in the first over, Sita and captain Indu Barma took Nepal to 44 runs in 6.4 overs before Sita departed at 17 runs off 15 deliveries.

Entering the crease at four, Kabita Joshi hit the first ball she faced, which was the fifth ball of the 7th over, for a four and took the team to 48/2. With only one ball remaining for the over to end, Maryam Omar bowled two continuous wide balls and gave Nepal the remaining two winning runs.

Meanwhile, Omar was the only wicket-taker for Kuwait as Sita was caught in her spell; Kabita got run out.



Nepal vs Malaysia

The Nepali women's cricket team has won five of the last seven matches against the Malaysian side played in the months of May, June and August last year.

Touring Malaysia for a series of 5 T20Is, Malaysia defeated Nepal in the first match of the series on May 29, 2023. The Nepali side then made a comeback by winning the second and third matches. The series became more competitive as Malaysia won the fourth match and levelled the series 2-2.

However, Nepal clinched the series by winning the final deciding match of the series by three wickets on June 4, 2023.

While Nepal lost against Malaysia in the group stage of the Women's T20 Quadrangular series on August 25, 2023, Nepal won the series defeating Hong Kong in the finals. Kuwait was the other team in the series.

Nepal then defeated Malaysia when they played in the ICC Women's T20 World Cup Asia Region Qualifier on August 31, 2023. Out of six teams with UAE as the group topper, Nepal was in the second position in Group A with 9 points while Malaysia was in third with 5 points at the end of the qualifiers' group stage.

Road to Asia Cup

The Women's T20 Asia Cup has been rescheduled for July by the Asian Cricket Council (ACC) where six teams are participating. Four full members of the ACC – India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka – will be taking part in the tournament without playing any qualifiers. The remaining two spots will be filled by the two finalists of the ACC Women's Premier Cup.

While Nepal is facing Malaysia, Thailand and UAE are facing off in the semi-finals. The winners, alongside qualifying for the Asia Cup, will progress to the finals and play for the ACC Women's Premier Cup trophy on February 18.

KOHLI'S ABSENCE HELPS ENGLAND'S CHANCES IN INDIA

AP
Rajkot, Feb. 14

The continued absence of Virat Kohli can only improve England's chances of a rare test series win in India. Not that Ben Stokes sees it like that.

"I think when it's a situation like this," the England captain said Wednesday, "when it's someone missing a big series and a lot of cricket for personal reasons which we're not sure of, I think we shouldn't label that as a positive or a negative to our team. "It should just be that it's a miss to cricket in general that Virat is not here."

Kohli, the world's most famous cricketer, announced ahead of the high-profile series that he would not play the first two tests because of personal reasons. The Board of Control for Cricket in India said at the time it respected Kohli's belief that "certain personal situations demand his presence and undivided attention" and confirmed Saturday that the superstar batter wouldn't be available for the final three tests, either.

Piedt eyes prospect of 'famous' win

AFP
Hamilton, Feb. 14

Recalled South African spinner Dane Piedt is eyeing a "famous, famous win" after claiming five New Zealand wickets Wednesday to give the understrength tourists a 31-run lead at stumps on the second day of the second Test.

New Zealand's batting succumbed to a disciplined attack led by Piedt, in his first Test since 2019, to be all out for 211 in response to South Africa's 242 in Hamilton.

A Proteas team with just 40 Test caps between them have opened up the prospect of squaring the two-match series after crashing to a 281-run loss in the first Test at Mount Maunganui.

The Proteas have never lost a Test series to New Zealand, but most of their first-choice players have stayed home for a domestic Twenty20 competition.



Piedt, who took career-best figures of 5-89 on a spin-friendly Seddon Park pitch, said his unheralded team had the self-belief to go on and win.

"It has been a tough tour but we have a great camaraderie inside that dressing room," he said. "We're quite open and honest with one another and hopefully those type of things will come through now.

"That's in the South African DNA and we'll fight as hard as we can now to get a famous, famous Test win."

The 33-year-old off-spinner, not needed for the first Test, claimed the key wickets of Kane Williamson for 43 and Tom Latham for 40 after lunch, with New Zealand having started soundly to reach 75-1.

Rachin Ravindra, who hit a double century in the first Test, played on to Tshepo Moreki for 29 at the start of a hectic third session in which seven wickets tumbled.

Using good variation and finding decent turn, he removed Glenn Phillips for four and Will Young for 36, along with the last wicket to fall of Neil Wagner, who had raced to 33 off 27 balls before he was stumped.

Dane Paterson was also effective for the Proteas, with his accurate seam bowling earning figures of 3-39.

His first wicket came in the opening over of the innings when struggling opener Devon Conway was caught behind without scoring.

The Proteas started day two at 220-6 but lost their last four wickets in just 8.2 overs as Will O'Rourke tore through the tail to finish with figures of 4-59 on debut.

O'Rourke bowled both of the overnight batsmen, with Shaun von Berg reaching 38 on debut and Ruan de Swardt 64.

Guardiola hails De Bruyne as City cruise towards CL quarters

AFP
Copenhagen, Feb. 14

Pep Guardiola hailed Kevin De Bruyne's form "extraordinary" after the Belgian was involved in all three goals as Manchester City beat FC Copenhagen 3-1 on Tuesday to close in on the Champions League quarter-finals.

De Bruyne's early opener was cancelled out against the run of play by Magnus Mattsson.

Bernardo Silva restored City's lead before half-time, but they had to wait until stoppage time to add further punishment for the hosts when Phil Foden turned home De Bruyne's cut-back.

De Bruyne was sidelined for five months by a hamstring tear suffered on the opening night of the Premier League season in August.

But since his return last month, the 32-year-old has scored two goals and provided seven assists in seven appearances. "Extraordinary," said Guardiola of De Bruyne's statistics. "The biggest players love to appear in the biggest stages.



The English champions have now won 11 consecutive games in all competitions as they remain on course to repeat last season's treble of Champions League, Premier League and FA Cup.

Copenhagen had not played a competitive game for two months since sealing their place in the last 16 by dumping out Manchester United and Galatasaray in the group stages.

Diaz dazzles in Real victory

Leipzig: An incredible solo goal from Brahim Diaz secured Real Madrid a 1-0 win away at RB Leipzig in Tuesday's Champions League last 16 first leg.

Leipzig were energetic but wasteful early, while Madrid goalkeeper Andriy Lunin made numerous saves after the hosts controversially had a goal disallowed for offside.

The German club were made to pay early in the second half when Diaz opened the scoring.

Drafted into the side in place of the injured Jude Bellingham, Diaz danced past three Leipzig defenders before curling an inch-perfect shot inside the far post.

"Im intuitive," said Diaz of the goal. "I saw Vini (Vinicius Junior) and wanted to give it to him, but in the end I took the shot. "It was a nice goal."

The win was Real Madrid's seventh in seven games this Champions League campaign and puts them in prime position to make it past the last 16 for the fourth straight season.

"It was an open match," said Leipzig goalkeeper Peter Gulacsi, contending that "a lucky punch decided the game".

Madrid travelled to Saxony without England midfielder Bellingham, who injured his ankle in Saturday's 4-0 win over Girona.

With first-choice centre-backs Antonio Ruediger, David Alaba and Eder Militao ruled out, coach Carlo Ancelotti opted to continue midfielder Aurelien Tchouameni's stint in central defence.

Despite their injury woes, Real sit five clear in the league and have only lost twice this season in all competitions, both times to derby rivals Atletico Madrid.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:42 am, Sunset at 5:55 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at one or two places of hilly region of Koshi Province. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province.

Expected Temp.: 22-24 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	25.8	8.0	0.0
Dadeldhura	19.3	5.7	0.0
Dhangadi	27.0	12.4	0.0
Birendranagar	24.5	11.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	26.2	13.0	0.0
Jumla	16.4	-0.9	0.0
Ghorahi	23.4	12.2	0.0
Pokhara	21.5	10.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.0	12.6	Traces
Simara	20.2	12.5	Traces
Kathmandu	16.8	7.2	Traces
Okhaldhunga	16.1	8.5	0.0
Taplejung	15.8	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	20.8	9.5	0.0
Biratnagar	23.2	8.8	0.0
Jomsom	11.0	-1.0	0.0*
Dharan	24.5	15.4	0.0*
Lumle	16.1	7.2	0.0*
Janakpur	22.6	13.8	0.0*
Jiri	15.1	0.9	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 15, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.56	Rs. 133.16
Euro	1	Rs. 141.83	Rs. 142.47
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.22	Rs. 166.98
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 149.33	Rs. 150.01
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 85.83	Rs. 86.22
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 97.91	Rs. 98.35
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.19	Rs.98.63
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.80	Rs. 8.84
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.43	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.35	Rs. 36.51
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.66	Rs. 3.68
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.09	Rs. 36.26
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.70	Rs. 27.82
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.93	Rs. 9.98
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.52	Rs. 12.58
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.03	Rs. 19.11
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 429.76	Rs. 431.71
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.63	Rs. 353.22

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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